Whose Champion? Early Donors and the Allocation of Legislative Attention

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Do the interests that back candidates early remain represented once they reach Congress? I examine whether legislators devote more attention to their early, or "seed," donors' policy interests than to those of their largest financial backers or their districts' distinctive industries. Using freshman cohorts entering the 107th through 115th U.S. Houses, I compare each member's activity across policy topics and committee hearings. Seed donor alignment is weakly related to party-line voting but positively associated with bill sponsorship and committee participation. Its relationship with committee participation depends on the venue: it is concentrated in committees whose jurisdiction covers the member's seed donors' interests. In these committees, seed donor alignment predicts participation more strongly than alignment with either largest donors or district industries, neither of which predicts participation there. The findings connect the financial coalitions formed before legislators enter office to their allocation of attention afterward, particularly where committee jurisdiction gives seed donors' concerns a place on the agenda.

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[2]I developed the research question, theoretical argument, research design, data collection and measurement strategy, interpretation of the results, and conclusions, and I wrote the initial draft of the manuscript. In subsequent revisions, I used generative AI tools (Claude/Claude Code) to assist with debugging and revising R/Python code and to suggest revisions for concision and grammar in drafts I had written. Language models were also used as independent classifiers in the topic-validation exercise described in the manuscript. I reviewed the code, analyses, and AI-assisted material retained in the final manuscript and assume full responsibility for the accuracy, integrity, and validity of the work.

1 Introduction

What does campaign money buy? Money has long been central to debates over unequal political representation in the United States, but how contributions matter once candidates reach office is still being explored. The classic concern is that donors influence the votes legislators cast. But lawmaking gives organized interests more than one point of influence. Contributions may matter earlier in the process, by shaping access, information, and the allocation of legislative attention. This paper starts from that broader possibility. Campaign relationships may matter less for how legislators vote than for which issues they choose to work on.

This perspective helps make sense of a longstanding empirical puzzle. Much of the campaign finance literature has looked for donor influence in roll-call voting, and the evidence is mixed (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003; Stratmann 2002; Wright 1990). If contributions operate through access and attention, that mixed evidence is not surprising. By the time an issue reaches the floor, the agenda has already been narrowed. Party positions are often clear, and individual legislators have little room to maneuver. A different line of work suggests that contributions help organized interests gain access to legislators who already share their goals, supply information and expertise, and shape how legislators allocate scarce time and effort (Austen-Smith 1995; Hall and Wayman 1990; Kalla and Broockman 2016). Consistent with this view, contributions and organized-interest activity have been linked to committee participation, access to legislators, bill advancement, and cosponsorship (Esterling 2007; Fong, McCrain, and Wineinger 2026; Grossmann and Pyle 2013; Hall and Wayman 1990; Powell and Grimmer 2016). These activities matter because attention is itself part of representation. Which issues receive questions, bills, and committee discussion helps determine what Congress works on in the first place.

This paper asks two related questions. First, whose interests are reflected in legislative attention? Second, where in the legislative process are those interests visible? I focus on early donors, or "seed donors": organized interests that back a candidate early in the run-

up to the first contested congressional primary. These donors enter when candidates are least established. Candidates do not yet have a congressional record, the advantages of incumbency, or a mature donor network. Early support can provide funding, credibility, and political connections while candidates are still building viability (Powell 2012). If relationships formed at this stage carry into office, they should remain visible in the issues legislators later choose to advance and discuss.

There are several reasons why early donor relationships might remain visible after the election. One possibility is obligation: candidates may feel a particular debt to supporters who backed them when their prospects were still uncertain. A second is screening: organized interests may be especially good at identifying candidates whose priorities already align with their own. A third is continuity: early supporters may connect candidates to policy networks that continue to provide information, expertise, and legislative help once they enter Congress.

The screening account is especially important for interpreting early donor alignment. Bawn et al. describe organized interests as shaping representation through *placement* rather than post-election control (Bawn et al. 2026; Bawn et al. 2012). Groups often have information and resources that allow them to evaluate candidates before most voters can. By supporting aligned candidates in primaries, they may help determine which policy commitments make it to Congress without changing legislators' preferences after election. I do not attempt to distinguish cleanly among obligation, screening, and continuity. Instead, I focus on their shared observable implication: relationships formed before Congress may remain visible in what legislators later choose to work on inside Congress.

To see whether those early relationships remain visible in Congress, I compare three forms of legislative activity that differ in how much discretion members have over what to do: roll-call voting, bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, and committee hearing speech. Roll-call voting is highly visible and strongly constrained by party. Sponsorship and cosponsorship give members more control over which issues they choose to advance or publicly support, while still leaving a visible record. Committee speech gives legislators still more latitude

over where to direct their attention. If donor relationships operate primarily through access and attention rather than vote buying, they should be hardest to see in roll-call voting and easier to see as legislative discretion increases.

Seed donors are not the only interests legislators have reason to represent. Once candidates reach Congress, they face strong incentives to respond to constituents (Fenno 1978; Mayhew 1974), while competition for party control gives them reason to advance partisan goals (Lee 2016). They also continue to raise money and attract new donors. These pressures operate in a political system in which economic elites and business groups often exercise more influence over policy than average citizens (Gilens and Page 2014). Wealthy Americans participate at unusually high rates and hold preferences that often differ from those of the broader public (Page, Bartels, and Seawright 2013), while organized mega-donor networks have become important actors in party politics (Hertel-Fernandez, Skocpol, and Sclar 2018). The question, then, is not simply whether donor-linked issues appear in legislative behavior. It is whether early donor interests remain visible alongside other plausible sources of legislative priority.

I compare three sources of legislative priorities: seed donors, legislators' largest donors, and their districts' economic interests. I study freshman cohorts entering the 107th through the 115th U.S. Houses and ask whether legislators devote more attention to issues associated with their seed donors than to those associated with their largest financial backers or their districts.

I begin with PAC contributions to candidates and identify the interests—industries or ideological policy demands—that contributing PACs represent. I then map these interests onto 30 common policy topics and use supervised classifiers to assign bills, roll-call votes, and committee hearing transcripts to the same topics. This common classification allows me to examine whether legislators are more likely to sponsor or cosponsor bills, speak at committee hearings, or depart from their party's position on votes concerning seed-donor topics than on topics associated with their largest donors or their districts.

I then test whether seed donor alignment is stronger on committees whose jurisdiction covers a member's seed topics, and examine heterogeneity across broader committee types: economic and distributive versus oversight committees, Deering and Smith's prestige, policy, and constituency types (Deering and Smith 1997), and individual committees. I also examine whether alignment changes as elections approach. To assess whether the findings reflect candidate selection or a continuing donor relationship, I examine electoral conditions, donor geography, continued giving, and members' final terms. Across these tests, I distinguish findings that persist across specifications from those that depend on particular choices.

Seed donor interests are barely related to party-line voting but are associated with bill sponsorship and committee speech. Legislators are 2.9 percentage points more likely to sponsor a bill on a seed donor topic, about a sixth of the base rate. They are also 2.6 points more likely to speak at a hearing on a seed donor topic, about an eighth of the base rate. In committee speech, the seed relationship is stronger than the district relationship, though members also speak more on topics tied to their largest non-seed donors.

The clearest differences appear on committees whose jurisdiction covers at least one of the member's seed topics. There, members are 4.1 points more likely to speak on seed topics, and seed alignment significantly exceeds both largest-donor and district alignment. Neither comparison interest is significantly associated with participation on these committees. The largest seed estimate is on the prestige committees that control taxing and spending, at 5.3 points. Together, the findings suggest that early donor ties are clearest where committee jurisdiction gives members an opportunity to work on their early backers' concerns.

The findings make three contributions. First, they show why *where* we look for donor relationships matters. Early donor ties are barely visible in floor votes but visible in agenda activity, consistent with an access-and-attention account of campaign finance (Austen-Smith 1995; Hall and Wayman 1990; Langbein 1986). Second, they show that *institutional opportunity*, not visibility alone, shapes where those ties appear. Seed donors' distinctive relationship with attention is concentrated where committee jurisdiction gives organized economic inter-

ests a place on the agenda (Fouirnaies and Hall 2018; Kroszner and Stratmann 1998; Witko 2006). Third, they show that the early financial coalition is distinct from the member's other major backers. Members' largest non-seed backers also predict participation, but in a different place: their topics draw attention on committees that do not cover the member's seed topics, while early backers' topics draw attention where the committee's jurisdiction covers them.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops the argument and hypotheses. Section 3 describes the data, measurement, and models. Section 4 presents the results. Section 5 discusses what the evidence can and cannot say about why early donor ties remain visible, and Section 6 concludes.

2 Theory and Hypotheses

Legislators cannot give equal attention to every issue. They must choose which bills to introduce, which hearings to participate in, and which problems to pursue. These choices reflect competing demands from constituents, parties, and financial supporters. Campaign relationships may help explain that allocation of effort. If organized interests support candidates whose priorities match their own, or maintain connections that provide information and legislative support, those relationships may remain visible in the issues members choose to work on after election.

Some of the relationships that inform these choices begin before legislators enter Congress. Organized interests that support candidates early may help them reach and remain connected to their policy work afterward. These early ties can help explain which issues members choose to pursue. Their expression also depends on where members have opportunities to act: legislators may attend to early backers' concerns through bill sponsorship or committee participation even when those relationships are difficult to observe in recorded votes. I examine both why early donor ties may persist and where they should appear in legislative

activity.

The Case of Early Donors Early donors are important because early money matters differently to candidates and to donors. For candidates, early contributions arrive when they have the least established political footing. Fundraising helps candidates build credibility and signal viability, particularly in primaries (Biersack, Herrnson, and Wilcox 1993; Thomsen 2023; Thomsen 2025). These benefits are especially important for newcomers, whose early contributions are associated with stronger fundraising later and with primary success (Porter and Steelman 2023). Early donors therefore provide support before candidates have a congressional record, the advantages of incumbency, or a mature donor network.

For donors, giving early is meaningful for a different reason. By contributing before a candidate has won a contested primary, organized interests are acting before there is much legislative behavior to reward. They are not simply responding to an established voting record or proven congressional influence. Instead, they are making an early judgment about the candidate's viability, priorities, and potential value as a future ally. That judgment may reflect private information, local political knowledge, policy agreement, or ties to the candidate's emerging political network.

These early relationships may remain visible after the election for several reasons. One is obligation. Candidates may feel particular gratitude toward donors who supported them when their prospects were still uncertain, consistent with evidence that legislators can be motivated to repay past favors and with the broader norm of reciprocity (Fong 2023; Gouldner 1960). A second is screening: organized interests may be especially good at identifying candidates whose policy commitments already match their own (Barber, Canes-Wrone, and Thrower 2017; Bawn et al. 2012). A third is continuity. Early support may connect candidates to policy networks that continue to provide information, expertise, and legislative help once they enter office, reinforcing issues the candidate already cared about (Esterling 2007; Hall and Deardorff 2006; Hall and Wayman 1990).

The screening account is particularly useful for interpreting early donor alignment. Bawn et al. argue that organized interests can shape representation through *placement* rather than post-election control (Bawn et al. 2026; Bawn et al. 2012). Groups may have limited ability to monitor or discipline legislators once they are in office, but they can evaluate candidates beforehand and support those who already share their goals. This strategy may be especially useful in primaries, where voters often have relatively little information for distinguishing candidates from the same party (Masket 2009). Donor priorities can therefore appear in Congress even if contributions never cause legislators to change their preferences.

These accounts imply different mechanisms, and I do not attempt to distinguish cleanly among them. What they share is the expectation that relationships formed early in a candidate's career may carry forward into office. Seed donor interests may remain visible because candidates feel an obligation to early supporters, because those supporters successfully identified aligned candidates, or because the political networks formed during the campaign persist after election.

Compared to Whom? Competing Priorities Early donors are not the only financial relationships legislators have reason to maintain. Once candidates enter Congress, their political environment changes. Incumbency makes legislators more attractive to new donors, many of whom give after the member has already demonstrated electoral viability and gained institutional access (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014). These later large donors may be more access-oriented than early supporters, and their giving can reflect the member's committee assignments, party position, or value within broader advocacy and partisan networks (Hertel-Fernandez, Skocpol, and Sclar 2018). Fundraising after election also matters inside Congress, where members' donor networks can shape opportunities for leadership and institutional advancement (Fong and McCrain 2025). The question, then, is whether relationships formed before office remain visible once these larger post-election donor coalitions emerge.

Legislators also have strong reasons to pay attention to their districts. Reelection gives members incentives to remain responsive to constituents (Fenno 1978; Mayhew 1974; Miller and Stokes 1963), and they can pay an electoral price when their records move too far from district preferences or too closely follow the party line (Canes-Wrone, Brady, and Cogan 2002; Carson et al. 2010). These pressures operate in a system where affluent citizens and organized business interests participate disproportionately and often exercise greater influence over policy than average citizens (Baumgartner et al. 2009; Gilens and Page 2014).

The relevant comparison, then, is not simply between donor-linked and non-donor issues. A legislator may have several competing relationships to represent. I compare seed donors with two alternatives: the member's largest financial backers and the economic interests of the district. These capture three different sources of pressure—an early donor relationship formed before office, major financial support that can develop later, and local economic interests tied to the constituency. If there is something distinctive about support that arrives early, seed donor interests should remain especially visible even after these other pressures enter the picture.

Discretion: Where Donor Ties Can Surface Where should these relationships appear? The answer depends on how much control legislators have over the activity in question. A vote-buying account predicts that contributions should shape recorded votes (Stratmann 1991; Stratmann 2002). An access-and-attention account points elsewhere: contributions may give organized interests access to sympathetic legislators and shape where those legislators spend their time and effort, without changing how they vote (Austen-Smith 1995; Hall and Wayman 1990; Langbein 1986).

Roll-call voting leaves relatively little room for an individualized donor relationship to appear. Floor votes are highly visible and heavily structured by party competition and organization (Aldrich and Rohde 2001; Lee 2016). By the time an issue reaches a recorded vote, party positions are often clear and much of the agenda-setting work has already happened.

I therefore ask whether members follow their party more or less closely on policy topics tied to their donors. This measure captures party-line adherence, not whether a particular vote agrees with the donor's preferred policy position. If early donor relationships matter mainly through access and attention, voting is where they should be hardest to detect.

Bill sponsorship and cosponsorship give members more choice over what to work on. Sponsoring a bill places an issue on the agenda, while cosponsoring allows legislators to publicly support issues being advanced by their colleagues (Koger 2003; Schiller 1995). Both leave a visible and searchable record, but unlike a floor vote, they require members to choose among many possible issues they could advance or support.

Committee work gives members still more room to direct their attention. Committees are central venues for developing, debating, and revising legislation (Deering and Smith 1997; Fenno 1973; Krehbiel 1992), but much of that work receives far less public attention than a recorded floor vote (Arnold 1990; Wilson 1885). As Wilson famously put it, "Congress in session is Congress on public exhibition, whilst Congress in its committee-rooms is Congress at work" (Wilson 1885). Members choose which questions to ask, which arguments to pursue, and which problems to emphasize. Party leaders still shape committee activity, but they do not fully determine how individual members use their time there (Curry and Lee 2020).

This is also where existing research gives organized interests good reason to invest. Contributions are associated with committee participation and attention to policy analysis (Esterling 2007; Hall and Wayman 1990), can facilitate access to congressional officials (Kalla and Broockman 2016), and flow toward legislators with valuable committee influence (Powell and Grimmer 2016). Organized interests likewise concentrate their lobbying on committee allies and on the bills they most want to move forward (Grossmann and Pyle 2013; Hojnacki and Kimball 1998).

The expectation is therefore a simple one. Seed donor alignment should be least apparent in roll-call voting, more apparent in sponsorship and cosponsorship, and most consistently visible in committee speech. Put differently, early money should be easier to see in what

legislators choose to work on than in how they vote.

Institutional Opportunity: Jurisdiction and Policy Stakes The second feature is *jurisdiction and policy stakes*. Discretion is necessary but not sufficient. A member also needs a venue where the concerns tied to a donor relationship are on the agenda. Organized economic interests seek access to the committees that write the rules for their industries (Fouirnaies and Hall 2018; Kroszner and Stratmann 1998). Their influence is greatest on low-salience, particularistic questions (Witko 2006; Denzau and Munger 1986). The most direct opportunity comes from a committee whose jurisdiction covers the issues a member's early backers care about. Its hearings are where a member can most easily turn those backers' concerns into questions, requests, and framing. A member whose seed donors are banks has that opportunity on a committee that oversees financial regulation, and much less on one that does not. Beyond a specific committee's jurisdiction, broader committee types may also matter. Hearings of the economic and distributive committees, such as Financial Services, Energy and Commerce, Agriculture, and Transportation, deal with the rules that govern industries.

The prestige committees in Deering and Smith's typology extend this logic (Deering and Smith 1997). Appropriations, Ways and Means, and Budget oversee taxing and spending decisions that affect a wide range of industries. Members seek seats on these committees because of their influence over distributive decisions. Rules is also classified as a prestige committee, but its influence comes primarily from control over legislative procedure. Oversight, homeland security, judiciary, and foreign affairs committees often address investigations, executive oversight, national security, and legal disputes (Kriner and Schickler 2016; Park 2021). Their agendas may therefore be shaped more strongly by party priorities than by the policy interests of individual donors.

These distinctions suggest that early donor alignment may vary across committee types. Early donor ties should be most visible when a member serves on a committee whose jurisdic-

tion covers the policy interests of their early backers. Differences in committee responsibilities may also shape the strength of this relationship across economic and distributive, prestige, and oversight committees.

Hypotheses

I refer to the interests that backed a legislator early in the run-up to the first contested primary as the legislator's "seed donors." I test the following hypotheses across three stages of the legislative process: roll-call voting, bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, and committee speech.

H1. Discretionary Attention Legislators devote more attention to topics tied to their seed donors in activities that give them discretion: bill sponsorship and committee speech. In party-line voting, where discretion is limited, seed donor interests should show little relationship.

H2. Institutional Opportunity In committee speech, the relationship between seed donor interests and participation is stronger on committees whose jurisdiction covers the member's seed topics than on other committees. On those committees, seed alignment should also exceed alignment with the member's largest non-seed backers and the district's specialized industries.[3]

3 Data, Methods, and Models

To test these expectations, I proceed in three steps (Figure 1). First, I identify each legislator's seed donors, largest financial backers, and district economic interests. I use PAC contribution records to identify donor interests and district employment and payroll data to identify distinctive local industries. I map all three sets of interests onto a common set of 30 policy topics. Second, I use supervised classifiers to assign committee hearings, bills, and roll-call votes to the same topics. This allows me to identify whether each legislative activity concerns a topic associated with the member's seed donors, largest donors, or district.

[3] I also explore heterogeneity across different committee types, comparing economic, distributive, and prestige committees with oversight, security, and legal committees. I report the committee-type comparisons in Section 4.3.

Third, I estimate models comparing topics and hearings within legislators. These models test whether members are more likely to sponsor or cosponsor bills, speak at hearings, or vote with their party on topics associated with each source of legislative priority.

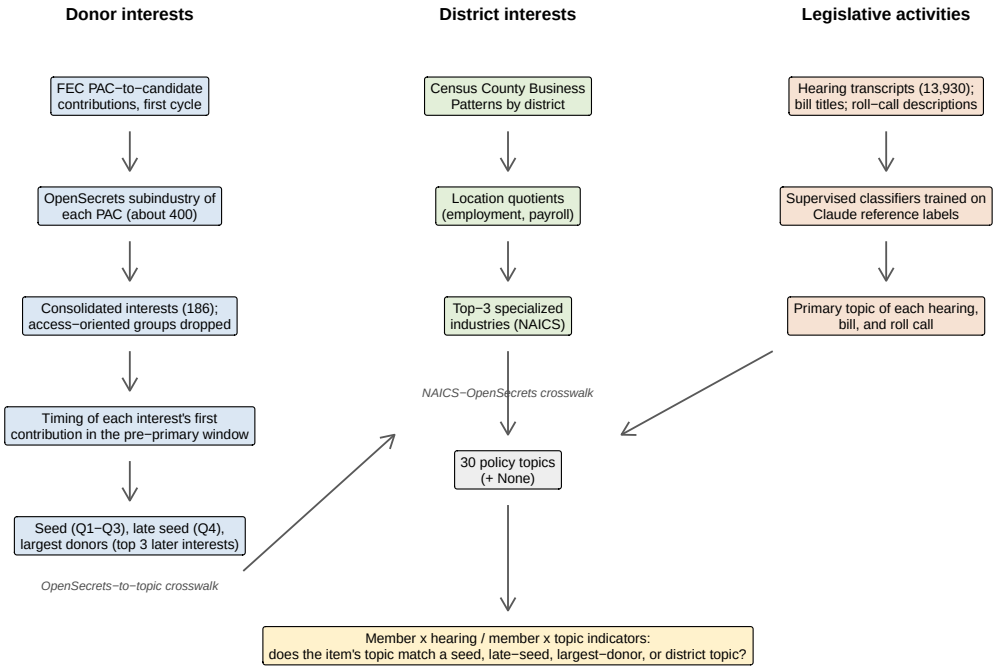


Figure 1: From Contributions, Districts, and Legislative Records to Common Policy Topics

Note: Donor interests, district interests, and legislative activities are each mapped to the same 30 policy topics, plus a residual "None." The analysis then asks whether a hearing's or bill's topic matches one of the member's seed, late-seed, largest-donor, or district topics.

3.1 Scope and Data

I follow freshman House cohorts entering between the 107th and 115th Congresses and observe their legislative behavior through January 2019. "Freshman" means a first term in the House. Using Voteview member records, I exclude members who had served before, either in an earlier stint or after a special election in the preceding Congress.[4] The sample contains 350 members. I focus on freshmen because they have not yet built a legislative record that

[4]The 25 excluded members include members who served in the 1980s or 1990s and returned after an absence, and members who entered through a special election late in the preceding Congress.

donors can reward or punish. Their earliest financing relationships are tied to their entry into politics rather than to an established record.

PAC contributions for the 2000–2016 election cycles come from the FEC *Committee-to-Candidate* files.[5] PAC industry affiliations come from *OpenSecrets*. State primary dates come from *Ballotpedia* and the FEC. Each contributing PAC's home state comes from its registered state in the FEC committee master file.[6] Entry type comes from the FEC's incumbent–challenger–open-seat code. District partisanship comes from the Cook Partisan Voting Index (Cook Political Report 2024), and election returns from the MIT Election Data and Science Lab (MIT Election Data and Science Lab 2017). District economic interests are built from Census *County Business Patterns*. Committee assignments come from the congressional directory at *GovInfo*.

For committee speech, I use all 13,930 House committee hearing transcripts from the 107th to the 115th Congress available from the Government Publishing Office (Appendix Figure A1). For roll-call voting, I use all recorded House floor votes from *Voteview* (Lewis et al. 2024). For bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, I use bill introduction and cosponsorship records from *Congress.gov* (U.S. Congress 2024).

3.2 Step 1: Identifying Interests and Their Connections to Legislators

Interests The unit of analysis is interests: coalitions of groups with shared goals. I group PACs within the same industry or value group using the *OpenSecrets* PAC-to-industry crosswalk, which sorts PACs into roughly 500 subindustries and value groups.[7] I aggregate donations from PACs within each subindustry and treat them as contributions from a single interest. I then consolidate related subindustries by hand, guided by NAICS groupings and

[5] Leadership PACs are excluded. The 2014 and 2016 cycles are drawn from complete rebuilds of the FEC files.

[6] Using the PAC's registered state, 11–18% of PAC contributions to freshmen come from in-state PACs.

[7] Working at the subindustry level separates, for example, "Insurance Brokers," "Life Insurance," "Casualty Insurance," and "Accident and Health Insurance" within the insurance industry.

substantive similarity. I exclude access-oriented categories such as lawyers and lobbyists, whose policy alliances vary across election cycles (Kalla and Broockman 2016). Interests are then mapped to 30 policy topics.

In practice, little aggregation occurs. The typical seed interest is a single PAC: 60% of seed interests consist of one PAC. Even when several PACs are grouped together, one usually dominates. In 86% of seed interests, a single PAC supplies at least half of the dollars. And when an interest combines several PACs, they give to the two parties in similar proportions. For each PAC, I compute the share of its contributions that goes to Republicans. Within an interest, these shares barely differ: the typical standard deviation is 0.11, or about 11 percentage points. PACs grouped into the same interest lean the same way rather than forming opposing camps (Appendix Table A5).

Seed Donors For each legislator's first election cycle, I aggregate PAC contributions within each interest from January 1 of the year before the election through the general election. An interest is a pre-primary donor if its contributions exceed $5,000 and its first contribution preceded the legislator's first contested primary.[8]

I then divide each legislator's pre-primary window into quarters. The window runs from the candidate's first PAC contribution of the cycle to the primary. Each interest is assigned to the quarter in which its first contribution arrived:

$$\text{position} = \frac{\text{first contribution by the interest} - \text{first contribution to the candidate}}{\text{primary date} - \text{first contribution to the candidate}}.$$

Seed donors are pre-primary donors that first gave in the first three quarters of the window. Pre-primary donors that first gave only in the final quarter are *late seed* donors. Every model includes them as a separate term.

I distinguish seed donors from interests that first contribute in the final quarter of the

[8]The threshold is generous. Serious donors typically aim for the maximum a single PAC may give, and an interest usually contains several PACs.

pre-primary window because late support may follow emerging viability rather than help establish it. Compared with earlier donors, last-quarter donors give less and more often arrive after the candidate leads the primary field in PAC receipts.[9] As such, "seed donors" only includes interests that first contribute in the first three quarters and treats final-quarter donors separately.[10]

Largest Donors I compare seed donors with the member's largest financial backers outside the original early donor coalition. In the first election cycle, I identify the three interests that contributed the most among those that first gave after the primary. These are the largest backers who arrived after the nomination was settled. In later cycles, I identify the three interests that contributed the most in that cycle, excluding the member's original seed and late-seed interests. Contributions can arrive before or after that cycle's primary, so this measure includes repeat donors who give early in each reelection campaign. Seed interests remain fixed at entry, while largest-donor interests can change from one cycle to the next.

District Interests Next, I identify each legislator's district interests. Since there is no comprehensive database of policy demands for congressional districts, I assume that districts are likely to favor policies that support industries in which they are distinctively specialized, rather than industries that are simply large everywhere. Ranking industries by raw share conflates size with specialization: a district's largest industry by raw share is often just the largest industry nationally (e.g., health care or retail trade), which does little to distinguish one district's economic interests from another's.

I construct location quotients (LQ) from Census *County Business Patterns*, a standard

[9] Appendix Figure A2 and Table A6 describe these patterns. The final quarter accounts for 36% of new pre-primary interests. Within the same candidate's donor coalition, last-quarter interests contribute 0.42 fewer log first-cycle dollars and are 14 percentage points less likely to exceed \$5,000 (both $p < 0.001$). They are 20.5 points more likely to arrive when the candidate leads the primary field in PAC receipts ($p < 0.001$), although part of this difference reflects the passage of time. They are also less likely to fund a same-party primary rival (-6.1 points, $p < 0.001$). These patterns are consistent with following viability, but do not establish when electoral uncertainty ends.

[10] I also report all main results using the broader pre-primary definition and entering the four quarters separately.

tool in regional economics (Isard 1960). For industry i in district d,

$$LQ_{i,d} = \frac{E_{i,d}/E_d}{E_i/E},$$

where $E_{i,d}$ is district d's employment (or payroll) in industry i, E_d is the district's total, E_i is national employment (or payroll) in industry i, and E is the national total. An LQ above one means the district is more specialized in the industry than the nation. The employment-based measure captures electoral salience: industries whose workers make up a disproportionate share of the district's labor force. The payroll-based measure captures economic salience: industries that account for a disproportionate share of local output. A topic is a district interest if it falls among the district's top three industries by either measure.[11] Census industries are linked to *OpenSecrets* interests through a NAICS-to-OpenSecrets crosswalk.

Overlap among the Three Interests Of the 350 members, 237 have at least one seed topic; the average member has 4.1 seed topics, 2.3 largest-donor topics, and 9.0 district topics. The three sets overlap, but not heavily. Among freshmen, 35% of seed topics are also district topics, while only 10% are also largest-donor topics (Appendix Table A3). Two-thirds of members with seed topics have at least one seed topic that is also a district topic, and about a third have one that is also a largest-donor topic. The indicators are only weakly correlated. In the speech panel, the Pearson correlation is 0.08 between seed and largest-donor alignment, 0.14 between seed and district alignment, and 0.14 between largest-donor and district alignment. In the bill and vote panel, all three are 0.06 or below (Appendix Table A4).

The excluded categories matter for the comparison. Early backers are often among a freshman's largest donors: if seed and late-seed interests were not excluded, about half of

[11] District interests follow the district's lines in each Congress, so they change with redistricting. Comparing each district's top industry under the location quotient with a raw-share ranking, the two disagree 82–91% of the time for employment and 73–85% of the time for payroll. As such, location quotient reorders industries substantially rather than reproducing raw shares.

members' three largest first-cycle donor interests would be early backers. Excluding them keeps the comparison one between the early coalition and the member's other major backers. Seed donors are led by insurance, banks, utilities, physicians, health care, and automobiles. Largest donors are led by banks, physicians, abortion-related groups, oil, and insurance (Appendix Table A2). Because early donors are often local industries, Section 4.5 uses several designs to separate seed from district interests.

3.3 Step 2: Classifying Legislative Activity into Policy Topics

Committee Hearings Hearing titles often provide too little detail to identify the policy interests discussed, particularly when a hearing covers several issues. As such, I use the full transcripts to classify hearings into policy topics.

I begin with topic labels assigned by Claude Opus 5.5 to 4,206 hearings. Claude reads a structured digest containing the hearing's title, committee, witness list, and opening text, then assigns a primary topic and up to two secondary topics.[12]

Using 1,606 of these labeled hearings, I train a supervised classifier to predict the primary topic from the full transcript. The classifier combines two models: one uses sentence embeddings to capture the meaning of the text, and the other uses topic-specific keyword scores.[13] I evaluate the classifier on 2,600 randomly sampled hearings excluded from training. Its primary topic agrees with Claude's label on 78% of these hearings (Appendix Table A7).

To assess agreement with human judgment, I independently code 300 randomly sampled hearing transcripts without seeing the machine assignments. The classifier's primary topic agrees with mine on 81% of hearings ($\kappa = 0.80$). Agreement rises to 94% when secondary-topic matches are included.

[12]Claude also assigned a confidence rating. Hearings with medium- or low-confidence labels were recoded using fuller digests. A blind recode of 60 high-confidence hearings reproduced the primary topic in 95% of cases. Because Claude produced both sets of labels, this measures consistency rather than accuracy.

[13]Both models are regularized multinomial logistic regressions. Transcripts are divided into roughly 200-word chunks and embedded using `bge-small-en-v1.5`. The embedding model uses the mean chunk embedding and measures of chunk similarity to descriptions of the 30 topics. Five-fold cross-validation selected weights of 0.6 for the embedding model and 0.4 for the dictionary model. Cross-validated agreement with the training labels is 86%.

Finally, I check whether the speech results depend on the topic measure by repeating the analysis with five alternatives: BERTopic (Grootendorst 2022), a structural topic model (Roberts, Stewart, Tingley, et al. 2014), keyATM estimated on all hearings (Eshima, Imai, and Sasaki 2024), an embedding zero-shot classifier, and pooled keyword topics. Each has lower agreement with Claude's reference labels than the supervised classifier (Appendix Table A8).

Bills and Roll Calls Bills and roll calls are classified into the same topics with a single multinomial logit fit to both, with an indicator for item type. For bills, the model uses the title, its sentence embedding, and the Congressional Research Service policy area. For roll calls, it uses the vote question and description and, when the vote concerns a House bill, that bill's title. Votes on amendments, resolutions, and other questions without an associated bill are classified from their own text, and purely procedural votes, such as adjournment, are coded "None." The classifier is trained on 3,140 Claude-labeled bills and roll calls, excluding 300 held-out items. On those items, it agrees with Claude's labels for 70% of bills and 84% of roll calls.[14]

3.4 Step 3: Constructing the Outcomes

The outcomes measure how members allocate attention across policy areas. Topic classification connects legislative activity to the issues associated with an interest. For example, speaking at a banking hearing indicates attention to banking policy, whether the member supports or opposes the banks' preferred position. The analysis therefore asks which issues members work on, rather than which positions they take.

Committee Speech The unit is a legislator–hearing pair. Every legislator on the roster of the committee holding a hearing is at risk of speaking at it, so the sample includes members

[14] I also report keyword-matching topics and the Congressional Research Service's human-assigned policy areas, mapped to coarse categories.

who stayed silent.[15] This lets me study the decision to participate, not only the volume of speech among members who spoke.[16] I identify each legislator's speaking turns using the transcript convention of a period-terminated surname (`"lastname."`). I exclude prepared statements submitted for the record, because they are written rather than delivered. I also exclude turns taken while chairing, because chair remarks are mostly procedural. The main outcome, *Spoke*, equals one if the legislator spoke at the hearing. I also report the number of *Speaking turns*. The speech panel contains 184,528 member–hearing observations for 350 members across 12,977 hearings (Appendix Table A1).[17] Members speak at least once in 22% of the hearings held by committees on which they serve.

For each hearing, I also record whether the member serves on the subcommittee holding it. I identify membership from the subcommittee roster printed in the transcript, usually after the full committee roster. For joint hearings, members of either subcommittee count as members.[18] Members speak much more often at their own subcommittees' hearings, which are also more likely to cover their topics of interest. As such, the speech models compare hearings at which a member has the same subcommittee membership status.

Bill Sponsorship and Cosponsorship The unit is a legislator–topic pair in the member's first Congress. *Sponsored* equals one if the legislator introduced at least one House bill on the topic. *Cosponsored* equals one if the legislator cosponsored at least one. The panel contains 10,500 observations for the 350 members.

[15] Speaking turns are attributed by surname, so a member is dropped from a hearing when another member of the same roster shares the surname. This affects 45 member–hearing observations for nine members.

[16] Only 15% of hearings actually list the members that are present. Appendix Table A25 uses those hearings to separate attending from speaking, and Appendix Table A24 reports the number of turns among members who spoke.

[17] The main models use 184,254 of these observations. The remaining observations lack a committee code or are the only observation in their fixed-effect group; such singletons do not affect the estimates. The Poisson models for speaking turns use 155,827 observations, because they also drop fixed-effect groups in which the member never speaks.

[18] Of the 12,977 hearings, 9,508 include a roster for the subcommittee holding the hearing. Sixty-two transcripts also list other subcommittees' rosters. Members listed only on those rosters do not count as members of the subcommittee holding the hearing.

Roll-Call Voting For each legislator and topic in the member's first Congress, *Party-line vote share* is the share of votes cast with the majority of the member's party (8,693 observations across 350 members). This measure captures party agreement rather than support for a donor's policy position. I use voting to compare legislative attention with a stage where party discipline leaves members less room to act on individual relationships. If donor ties appear mainly through access and attention earlier in lawmaking, their association with party-line voting should be small.

Explanatory Variables *Seed*, *Late Seed*, *Largest Donor*, and *District* are indicators equal to one if the topic of the hearing, or of the legislator–topic pair, matches at least one of the legislator's interests of that type. Seed interests are fixed at entry. Largest-donor interests are updated each cycle. District interests follow the district's lines in each Congress.

Committee Types To test H2, I map each committee's jurisdiction onto the 30 policy topics and record whether it covers at least one of the member's seed topics. This measure varies across members on the same committee. A committee that handles banking regulation covers a seed topic for a member backed by banks, but not for a member backed only by farm groups.

I also compare broader committee types using two classifications. The first groups committees by their policy stakes. Drawing on the distributive-politics literature, I distinguish committees that allocate benefits to identifiable industries and places from those focused on oversight, security, and legal questions (Adler and Lapinski 1997). The *economic and distributive* group covers tax, spending, financial, energy, agricultural, transportation, and infrastructure policy. It also includes Armed Services because procurement and basing decisions allocate benefits to particular firms and places (Carsey and Rundquist 1999).[19]

The second classification uses Deering and Smith's *prestige*, *policy*, and *constituency*

[19]The *oversight, security, and legal* group includes Oversight, Homeland Security, Judiciary, Foreign Affairs, Intelligence, House Administration, Rules, and Ethics. All other committees are classified as economic and distributive.

types (Deering and Smith 1997). Prestige committees are Appropriations, Ways and Means, Budget, and Rules.[20] These classifications capture different features of committees. Rules, for example, is a prestige committee but falls in the oversight, security, and legal group under the policy-stakes classification.

3.5 Statistical Models

The models compare each legislator's activity on seed topics with their activity on other topics, accounting for largest-donor and district interests. For committee speech, I estimate

$$Spoke_{ihct} = \beta_1 Seed_{ih} + \beta_2 LateSeed_{ih} + \beta_3 LargestDonor_{iht} + \beta_4 District_{iht} + \gamma_h + \delta_{icts} + \varepsilon_{ihct}, \quad (1)$$

where i indexes legislators, h hearings, c committees, t Congresses, and s whether the member serves on the subcommittee holding the hearing. Hearing fixed effects γ_h account for characteristics shared by members at the same hearing, such as its length and salience. Legislator $\times$ committee $\times$ Congress $\times$ subcommittee-membership fixed effects δ_{icts} account for each member's level of activity on a committee in a given Congress, separately by subcommittee membership status.

The seed coefficient therefore compares the same member's participation across hearings on the same committee, in the same Congress, and with the same subcommittee status. It asks whether the member is more likely to speak when the hearing concerns a seed topic.[21] I estimate participation with a linear probability model and the number of speaking turns with Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood.

For bills and votes, I estimate

$$Y_{ikt} = \beta_1 Seed_{ik} + \beta_2 LateSeed_{ik} + \beta_3 LargestDonor_{ikt} + \beta_4 District_{ikt} + \alpha_{it} + \tau_k + \varepsilon_{ikt}, \quad (2)$$

[20] Policy committees are Financial Services, Energy and Commerce, Education, Foreign Affairs, Oversight, and Judiciary. Constituency committees are Agriculture, Armed Services, Natural Resources, Science, Small Business, Transportation, and Veterans' Affairs.

[21] Because the model holds subcommittee membership status fixed, it does not capture any seed relationship that operates through members joining subcommittees that handle their early backers' issues.

where k indexes policy topics. Legislator $\times$ Congress fixed effects α_{it} account for each member's overall activity in that Congress, and topic fixed effects τ_k account for differences across topics. The seed coefficient compares the same member's activity on seed topics with their activity on other topics, after accounting for these differences.[22]

I cluster standard errors by legislator. To compare seed donors with the other interests, I report the differences between their coefficients: $\beta_1 - \beta_3$ for largest donors and $\beta_1 - \beta_4$ for district interests. These comparisons come from the same model and account for the covariance between the estimates.[23]

To test H2, I interact all four interest indicators with whether the committee's jurisdiction covers a member's seed topic. I use the same approach for the broader committee classifications. These models let me compare seed alignment across committee groups and with largest-donor and district alignment within each group.

4 Results

I begin with bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, then briefly report the voting results. I next examine committee speech and whether the seed relationship varies with committee jurisdiction and type. Finally, I assess whether district interests, topic measurement, or the grouping of PACs into interests account for the findings.

4.1 Bill Sponsorship and Cosponsorship

Members are more likely to sponsor bills on topics associated with their seed donors (Figure 2). Comparing the same member across topics, seed alignment is associated with a 2.9 percentage-point increase in the probability of sponsoring at least one bill ($p < 0.05$), about a

[22] The member fixed effects also account for stable differences across legislators, including ideology, party, entry type, and fundraising. The Appendix reports models using Congress fixed effects and member-level controls instead, as in an earlier version of the paper.

[23] For a comparison coefficient β_j, the standard error of the difference is $\sqrt{\mathrm{Var}(\beta_1) + \mathrm{Var}(\beta_j) - 2\,\mathrm{Cov}(\beta_1, \beta_j)}$, using the clustered covariance matrix.

sixth of the 18% base rate. Largest-donor alignment has little relationship with sponsorship (−0.5 points). The seed–largest-donor difference is 3.4 points ($p = 0.05$).

District interests are also associated with sponsorship. Members are 2.2 points more likely to sponsor a bill on a district topic ($p < 0.01$), and the seed–district difference is not significant. Seed alignment is not significantly associated with cosponsorship (1.4 points).[24]

These results partly support H1. Seed alignment is associated with sponsorship and exceeds largest-donor alignment, although that difference is less precisely estimated. It does not significantly exceed district alignment or predict cosponsorship.

The sponsorship relationship is also larger on topics within a member's committee jurisdiction. The seed estimate is 4.8 points for these topics ($p < 0.10$), compared with 2.0 points outside committee jurisdiction, although the difference is not significant. The district estimates differ more sharply: 8.8 points within committee jurisdiction ($p < 0.001$), compared with 0.3 points outside it (Appendix Table A16).

[24]Full estimates appear in Appendix Tables A10 and A11. The seed sponsorship estimate is 3.9 points with keyword-matching topics ($p < 0.01$) and 2.6 points under the broader pre-primary seed definition ($p < 0.05$). Models with Congress fixed effects and controls, rather than legislator × Congress fixed effects, give different results. Seed alignment is associated with cosponsorship (3.6 points, $p < 0.01$), while the sponsorship estimate is not significant (2.2 points). Largest-donor alignment is associated with cosponsorship (6.1 points, $p < 0.001$), and district alignment is negative for both outcomes (Appendix Figure A4).

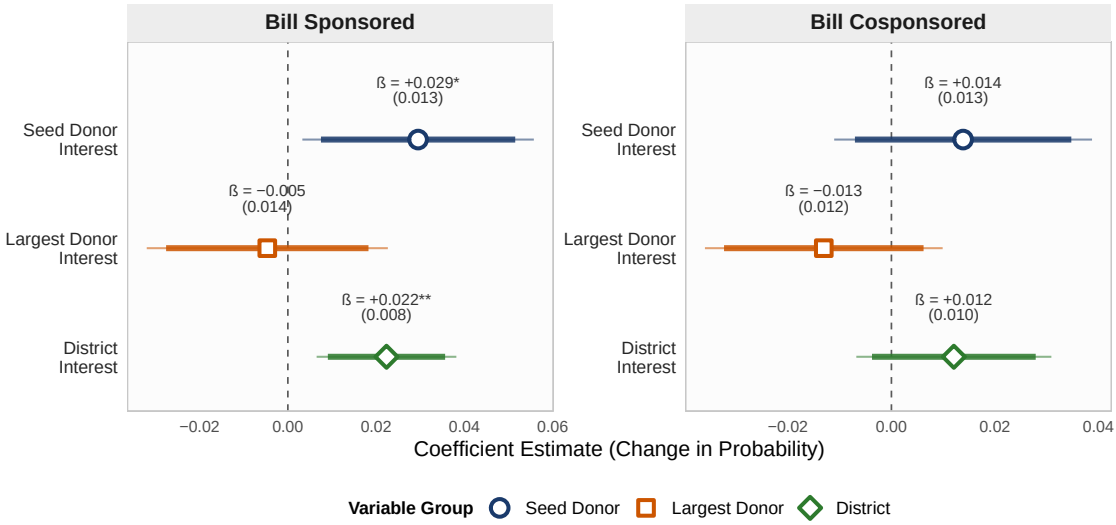


Figure 2: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests and Bill Activity

Note: Linear probability models of sponsoring (left) and cosponsoring (right) at least one bill on a topic. Observations are legislator × topic pairs in the member's first Congress. Models include legislator × Congress and topic fixed effects, with late-seed interests included separately. Circles denote seed donor interests, squares largest-donor interests, and diamonds district interests. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Roll-call Voting Seed donor interests have little relationship with party-line voting. Members vote with their party 0.9 percentage points more often on seed topics ($p < 0.10$), compared with an overall party-line voting rate of 94%. The largest-donor and district estimates are also small, at 0.4 and −0.3 points, respectively (Appendix Figure A3).[25] This small association is consistent with party discipline leaving little room for individual donor relationships to appear in recorded votes. The outcome measures agreement with the party, rather than support for donors' preferred policies.

4.2 Committee Speech

Members are more likely to speak at hearings on seed donor topics (Figure 3). Across all committees, seed alignment is associated with a 2.6 percentage-point increase in speaking probability ($p < 0.01$), about an eighth of the overall speaking rate of 22%. Largest-donor

[25] Full estimates appear in Appendix Table A9. A fractional logit with Congress fixed effects and controls gives a positive seed coefficient (0.26 on the log-odds scale, $p < 0.01$).

alignment is also associated with participation (1.3 points, $p < 0.05$), while the district estimate is small and not significant (0.5 points). Seed alignment exceeds district alignment by 2.1 points ($p < 0.05$). Its difference from largest-donor alignment is smaller and not significant (1.3 points).[26]

Seed alignment is more clearly associated with whether members speak than with how much they say once they participate. Among members who speak, the estimate for additional speaking turns is small and not significant.[27]

The participation relationship holds across all six topic measures. Estimates range from 1.5 points with the zero-shot classifier to 2.6 points with the supervised classifier, and all are positive and significant (Appendix Figure A7). Speech follows members through later Congresses, while bills and votes are measured only in their first Congress. Restricting speech to the first Congress gives a smaller estimate of 1.3 points, with less precision and about a third of the observations.

[26]Full estimates appear in Appendix Table A12. Seed alignment is associated with about 18% more speaking turns ($p < 0.01$), compared with about 2% for largest-donor and district alignment. With legislator $\times$ Congress fixed effects, the seed participation estimate is 2.5 points ($p < 0.01$). It is 3.3 points with a probability-weighted topic measure ($p < 0.01$) and 2.2 points under the broader pre-primary seed definition ($p < 0.01$). Without accounting for membership on the subcommittee holding the hearing, the estimate is 5.5 points. The smaller estimate after accounting for membership is consistent with members participating more often in their own subcommittees' hearings.

[27]The estimate is 0.4 additional turns under the main specification and 1.4 turns ($p < 0.01$) under the earlier specification with Congress and committee fixed effects (Appendix Table A24). In hearings whose transcripts list members present, seed alignment is associated with both attendance (2.9 points, $p < 0.05$) and speaking (4.5 points, $p < 0.05$). Among members recorded as present, the speaking estimate is 3.8 points and not significant (Appendix Table A25).

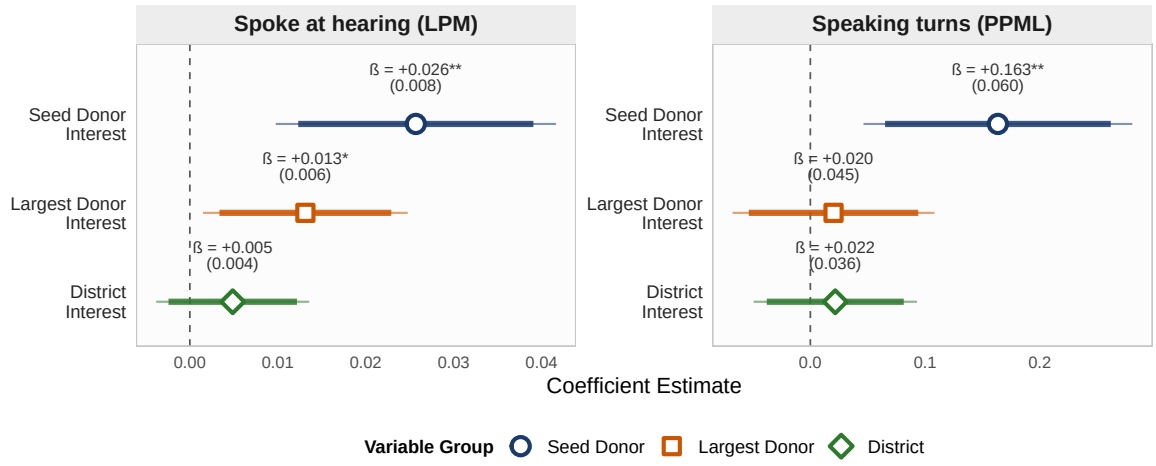


Figure 3: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests and Committee Speech

Note: Observations are legislator × hearing pairs for members serving on the hearing committee. Left: whether the member spoke, estimated with a linear probability model. Right: number of speaking turns, estimated with Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood. Models include hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects, with late-seed interests included separately. Circles denote seed donor interests, squares largest-donor interests, and diamonds district interests. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

4.3 Where Early Donor Ties Surface: Committee Jurisdiction

H2 expects seed alignment to be stronger on committees whose jurisdiction covers a member's seed topics and to exceed largest-donor and district alignment on those committees. Table 1 reports the jurisdiction comparison alongside estimates by broader committee type.

The results support H2. On committees whose jurisdiction covers at least one of the member's seed topics, members are 4.1 percentage points more likely to speak on seed topics ($p < 0.01$). Seed alignment exceeds largest-donor alignment by 4.2 points ($p < 0.01$) and district alignment by 4.2 points ($p < 0.05$). Neither largest-donor nor district alignment is significantly associated with participation on these committees.

On committees whose jurisdiction covers no seed topic, the seed estimate is smaller and not significant (0.8 points), while largest-donor alignment is associated with participation (2.1 points, $p < 0.001$). The seed estimate differs by 3.3 points between the two groups ($p < 0.05$). Early donor ties are therefore clearest where members serve on committees that

handle their early backers' issues. The seed estimate on these committees is positive and significant under all six topic measures (Appendix Figure A6).

Table 1: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Alignment in Committee Speech by Committee Jurisdiction and Type

Committee grouping	Seed	Largest donor	District	Members (seed obs.)
Jurisdiction (H2)				
Jurisdiction covers a seed topic	4.1^{**}	-0.2	-0.1	
Jurisdiction covers no seed topic	0.8	2.1^{***}	0.7	
Difference	3.3^{*}	-2.3	-0.8	
Committee type				
Economic/distributive	3.0^{**}	1.0	0.3	192 (16,761)
Oversight/security/legal	1.4	2.4^{*}	1.0	100 (3,089)
Difference	1.5	-1.4	-0.7	
Prestige	5.3^{**}	2.7	-1.5	70 (2,055)
Policy	2.7^{*}	1.4^{+}	1.0^{+}	142 (12,252)
Constituency	1.9^{+}	0.7	-0.1	137 (5,179)

Note: Estimates are percentage-point differences in the probability of speaking at a hearing. Each block reports a model interacting seed, late-seed, largest-donor, and district alignment with the committee grouping. Models include hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered by legislator. Members are those with at least one seed-matched observation in the group; seed obs. are seed-matched member–hearing observations. Difference rows subtract the second group from the first within each block. Full estimates and contrasts appear in Appendix Table A13. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

4.4 Heterogeneity by Committee Type

Figure 4 compares seed alignment across broader committee types. These groups capture committees' policy stakes and institutional roles, while the jurisdiction measure captures whether a committee handles a particular member's seed topics.

Economic and distributive committees Members are 3.0 percentage points more likely to speak on seed topics in economic and distributive committees ($p < 0.01$). Seed alignment exceeds district alignment by 2.7 points ($p < 0.05$), but its difference from largest-donor alignment is not significant (1.9 points). In oversight, security, and legal committees, the seed estimate is smaller and not significant (1.4 points). The difference between the two

committee groups is also not significant (1.5 points).

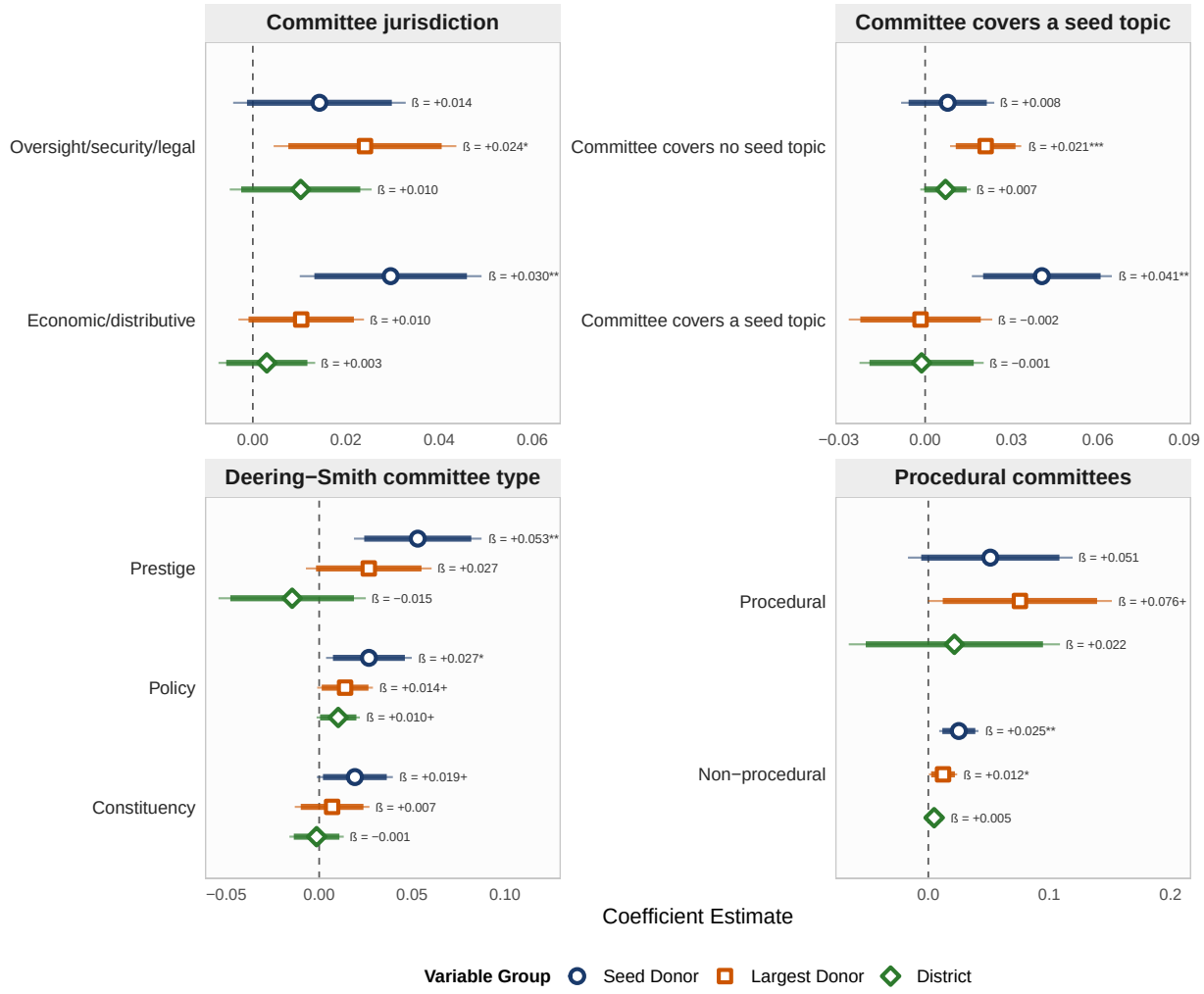


Figure 4: Seed Alignment in Committee Speech by Committee Type

Note: Each panel reports a model interacting seed, late-seed, largest-donor, and district alignment with the committee grouping. The outcome is whether the member spoke at the hearing. Models include hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Prestige committees The largest seed estimate appears on prestige committees, at 5.3 points ($p < 0.01$). Seed alignment exceeds district alignment by 6.8 points ($p < 0.05$), but its difference from largest-donor alignment is not significant (2.6 points).[28] The seed estimates

[28]The prestige group includes Appropriations, Ways and Means, Budget, and Rules. Rules contributes only 35 member–hearing observations, three on seed topics, so the seed estimate primarily reflects the three

are smaller on policy committees (2.7 points, $p < 0.05$) and constituency committees (1.9 points, $p < 0.10$).

The prestige estimate is significant under four of the six topic measures. The economic-versus-oversight difference is positive under four measures but significant under none (Appendix Figure A6).[29]

Individual committees Figure 5 reports estimates for individual committees. The largest seed estimates are on Natural Resources (6.9 points, $p < 0.01$), Ways and Means (6.0 points, $p < 0.05$), Judiciary (4.4 points, $p < 0.01$), and Small Business (4.1 points, $p < 0.05$).

On Natural Resources, seed alignment exceeds both largest-donor alignment (by 8.4 points, $p < 0.05$) and district alignment (by 10.9 points, $p < 0.001$). On Ways and Means and Agriculture, seed alignment exceeds district alignment by 8.6 and 9.4 points, respectively (both $p < 0.05$), although the Agriculture seed estimate itself is imprecise. Judiciary shows that the relationship is not limited to economic and distributive committees: its seed estimate is positive and significant despite its inclusion in the oversight, security, and legal group. The estimate on Oversight is small and not significant (0.7 points).[30]

fiscal committees. Across the prestige committees, 70 members have at least one seed-matched observation, accounting for 2,055 seed-matched member–hearing observations. The committee-specific counts are 30 members on Ways and Means, 40 on Budget, and 14 on Appropriations; members may appear on more than one committee.

[29] After earlier analyses, I selected three tests for a multiple-comparison adjustment: sponsorship, the economic-versus-oversight difference, and the prestige estimate. Their raw p-values are 0.027, 0.233, and 0.002; the Holm-adjusted values are 0.055, 0.233, and 0.007 (Appendix Table A17). This adjustment covers these three tests, which were not specified in advance, and does not account for earlier comparisons across seed definitions, committee groupings, and moderators.

[30] Appendix Table A15 reports results for all committees, including those with too few observations to appear in the figure. The Online Supplement reports speaking turns by committee. Appendix Figure A5 reports the seed–district and seed–largest-donor differences.

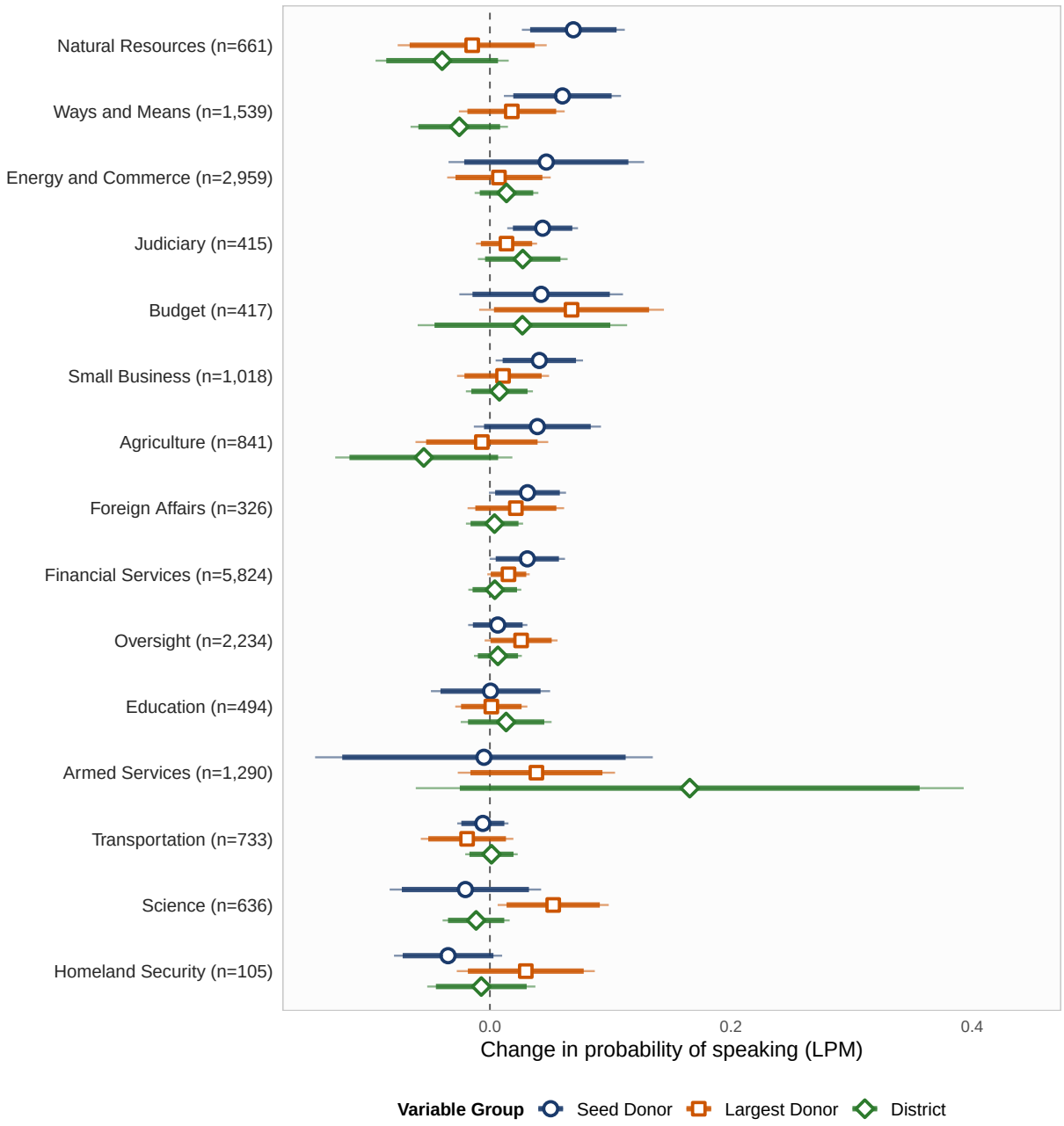


Figure 5: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Alignment in Committee Speech, by Committee

Note: A single model interacts seed, late-seed, largest-donor, and district alignment with each committee. The outcome is whether the member spoke at the hearing. Models include hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Circles denote seed donor interests, squares largest-donor interests, and diamonds district interests. Committees are ordered by the seed coefficient; n denotes seed-matched member–hearing observations. Committees with fewer than 2,000 observations or 100 seed-matched observations are not shown. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Early donor ties are associated with sponsorship and committee participation, while their relationship with party-line voting is small. In committee speech, seed alignment exceeds district alignment overall, but its advantage over largest donors depends on committee jurisdiction. It exceeds both comparison interests on committees that handle the member's seed topics. The broader committee classifications show larger estimates in some venues, especially prestige committees, but committee jurisdiction provides the clearest support for H2.

4.5 Competing Explanations

District interests Because 35% of seed topics are also district topics, the seed relationship could reflect attention to local industries. Figure 6 separates these interests. The left panel reports mutually exclusive combinations of seed, largest-donor, and district alignment. The right panel compares members who held the same district seat in the same map era.

Members are 3.0 percentage points more likely to speak on topics tied only to seed donors ($p < 0.01$), compared with 0.6 points for district-only topics. The difference is 2.4 points ($p < 0.05$). Topics tied to both seed donors and district interests have an estimate of 4.0 points ($p < 0.001$), exceeding district-only topics by 3.4 points ($p < 0.01$). Largest-donor-only topics are also associated with participation (2.1 points, $p < 0.01$), and their difference from seed-only topics is not significant. Seed ties are thus associated with attention even when they do not overlap with measured district interests.[31]

The seed estimate remains at 2.6 points ($p < 0.01$) under each of three alternative district measures. The same-seat and redistricting comparisons are less precise and do not show significant seed relationships.[32] The overlap and alternative-measure results suggest

[31] Appendix Tables A20 and A21 report all seven combinations and their contrasts. Seed-only topics are associated with about 25% more speaking turns ($p < 0.01$). In sponsorship, the seed-only estimate is close to zero (0.2 points). Topics tied to both seed donors and district interests, however, exceed district-only topics by 5.7 points in sponsorship ($p < 0.05$) and 3.6 points in cosponsorship ($p < 0.10$).

[32] Comparing members who held the same seat in the same map era gives a seed estimate of 0.8 points. Estimates relating redistricting-induced changes in district interests to speech are 0.6 points on non-seed topics and 0.9 points on seed topics. None is significant. Full results appear in Appendix Tables A18

that district specialization does not fully account for the seed relationship, although these measures do not capture all constituent demands.

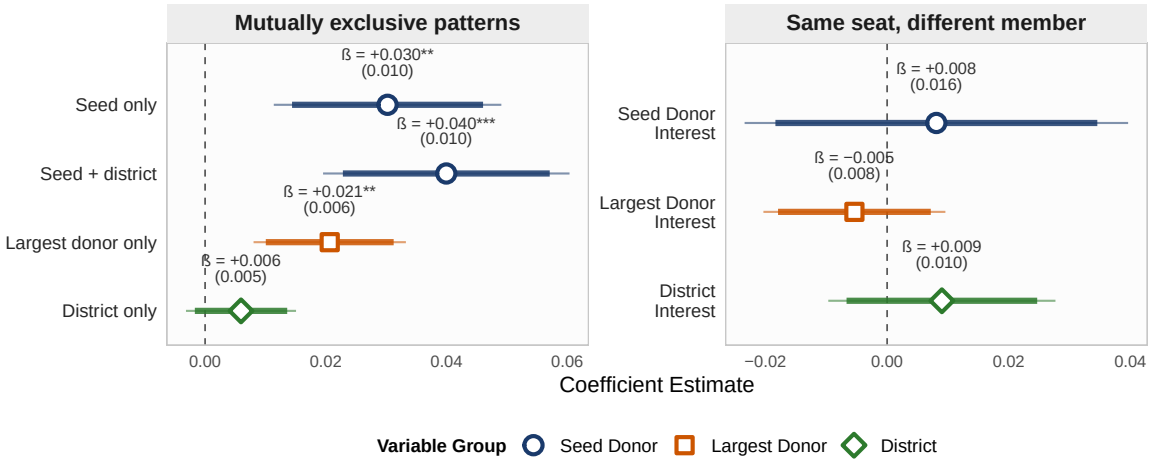


Figure 6: Separating Seed from District Interests in Committee Speech

Note: Left: mutually exclusive alignment patterns estimated in one model. Right: adds seat × map era × hearing topic fixed effects to compare members who held the same seat. The outcome is whether the member spoke at the hearing. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Topic measurement The speech relationship holds across all six topic measures (Appendix Figure A7). The pooled seed estimate is largest with the supervised classifier, which also agrees most often with Claude's reference labels. It is somewhat larger among hearings classified with greater confidence: 2.9 points versus 1.9 points (both $p < 0.01$), although the difference is not significant.

Aggregation I also compare seed topics backed by several PACs with those dominated by one PAC. In committee speech, the estimate is larger for topics backed by several PACs: 5.9 points ($p < 0.001$), compared with 1.9 points ($p < 0.05$). The difference is 4.1 points ($p < 0.01$). Sponsorship follows the same pattern, at 6.4 versus 2.2 points, although the difference is not significant (Appendix Table A22). The seed relationship is therefore stronger where support comes from several PACs, though these estimates do not establish that the

and A19.

PACs share a policy position.

5 Discussion

5.1 Early Donor Ties and Committee Jurisdiction

Early donor ties are associated with bill sponsorship and committee participation, while their relationship with party-line voting is small. In committee speech, their distinctive relationship with attention is clearest on committees whose jurisdiction covers the member's seed topics. There, seed alignment exceeds both largest-donor and district alignment. Neither comparison interest is significantly associated with participation on those committees.

The largest seed estimate appears on prestige committees that control taxing and spending, where seed alignment exceeds district alignment but not largest-donor alignment. The broader difference between economic and distributive committees and oversight, security, and legal committees is not significant. Individual committees also vary: Judiciary has a large positive seed estimate despite belonging to the latter group.

These findings support the expectation that committee jurisdiction shapes where early donor ties appear. Members have discretion over whether to participate in hearings, but the relationship with seed interests is stronger where their committees handle those interests' concerns. This pattern is consistent with work linking organized interests' contributions and access to committee jurisdiction (Fouirnaies and Hall 2018; Kroszner and Stratmann 1998; Witko 2006). Although I do not measure the visibility of individual hearings, the results suggest that studies of donor relationships should consider both members' discretion and their opportunities to address donors' issues.

5.2 Seed Donors, Largest Donors, and District Interests

Seed donors and largest donors are associated with different patterns of attention. Largest-donor alignment has little relationship with sponsorship but is associated with committee

participation overall. In speech, that relationship appears on committees whose jurisdiction does not cover the member's seed topics. On committees that cover those topics, seed alignment is stronger, while largest-donor alignment is small and not significant.

The two donor groups also enter at different stages. In the first election cycle, largest donors are interests that first contributed after the primary. In later cycles, the measure captures major backers outside the original early coalition, whose giving may follow committee assignments and incumbency (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014; Fouirnaies and Hall 2018). The findings show that the coalition formed at entry has a different relationship with legislative attention from the member's other major financial backers.

District interests resemble seed interests more closely in sponsorship. Both are positively associated with bill introduction, and the district relationship is especially large on topics within members' committee jurisdictions. Seed ties also add most to sponsorship where they overlap with district interests.

In committee speech, the district estimate is small and not significant, and seed alignment exceeds it overall, on economic and distributive committees, on prestige committees, and on committees that cover seed topics. Seed-only topics are also associated with more participation than district-only topics. These findings suggest that the seed relationship is not fully explained by attention to local industries, although economic specialization captures only part of what constituents want from their representatives.

5.3 Why Do Early Donor Ties Remain Visible?

The findings do not distinguish among obligation, screening, and continuity. I examine electoral conditions, donor geography, continued giving, and members' final terms to assess whether the patterns are consistent with these explanations. These comparisons are exploratory.

Electoral conditions A placement account suggests that early donor alignment may be stronger where groups have more opportunity to help aligned candidates reach office, especially in open-seat races and districts with limited electoral competition (Bawn et al. 2012; Hall 2015).

The speech estimate is larger among open-seat entrants: 3.0 points ($p < 0.01$), compared with 0.2 points among members who defeated an incumbent. The difference is marginally significant ($p < 0.10$). It is also larger among members whose first race was not close, at 2.9 points ($p < 0.01$), compared with 1.2 points among those who won narrowly, although that difference is not significant (Appendix Figure A8 and Table A26).

Sponsorship shows a different pattern. Members who won their first race narrowly are more likely to sponsor bills on seed topics (5.7 points, $p < 0.05$), though the estimate does not significantly exceed that for other members. These members also sponsor more bills on district topics, consistent with work linking electoral vulnerability to constituency representation (Canes-Wrone, Brady, and Cogan 2002; Griffin 2006). The electoral comparisons therefore provide limited evidence for distinguishing placement from a continuing donor relationship.

Geography The speech relationship is not limited to donors registered in the member's state. Only 11–18% of contributions to freshmen come from PACs registered in-state, and most members receive most of their seed money from out-of-state PACs. The speech estimate is 2.6 points for out-of-state seed interests ($p < 0.01$), compared with 0.4 points for in-state interests. Among members whose seed money came mostly from out of state, the estimate is 2.9 points ($p < 0.001$). In sponsorship, the in-state and out-of-state estimates are similar (Appendix Figure A9 and Table A27).

These results suggest that the seed relationship extends beyond ties to PACs registered locally. PAC registration addresses, however, do not capture the full geographic reach of the organizations they represent.[33]

[33] An earlier version found that seed alignment was concentrated among in-state donors. That result used

Continued giving and final terms Most seed donors continue to support the member: 89% give again in the next cycle. In committee speech, the seed relationship is stronger when the interest continues giving. Topics tied to seed interests that still contribute are associated with 2.6 points more speaking ($p < 0.01$). When the interest stops giving and the member runs again, the estimate is close to zero (−0.6 points). The difference is 3.2 points ($p < 0.05$; Appendix Table A28).

This pattern is consistent with a relationship maintained after entry, but the relationship may also run in the other direction. Donors may continue giving when members remain active on their issues and stop when members' priorities change.

Seed alignment in speech also weakens in a member's final Congress, by 2.9 points relative to earlier terms ($p < 0.05$), while largest-donor and district alignment do not change significantly. The decline is larger among members who do not appear on the next general-election ballot (−3.7 points, $p < 0.05$) than among those defeated in the general election (−0.4 points; Appendix Table A29).

For members who know they are leaving, reduced attention to seed topics could reflect the end of incentives to maintain the relationship. But the group also includes members who lose a primary or seek another office, and the analysis does not establish when members knew their House service would end. Changes in priorities or legislative activity during the final term could also contribute.

The continued-giving and final-term findings suggest that seed alignment may involve relationships maintained after entry. They do not establish exchange or rule out selection. Early backers may identify candidates with compatible priorities, help them reach office, and remain a source of information and support afterward.[34][35]

the state field in the FEC contribution record, which records the recipient committee's address rather than the donor's. The pattern disappears when geography is measured using the contributing PAC's registered state.

[34]The continued-giving and final-term tests were selected after earlier analyses and should be treated as exploratory. When added to the three tests reported in Appendix Table A17, only the prestige estimate remains significant at the 0.05 level after Holm's correction. The Appendix reports the raw and adjusted p-values.

[35]Additional exploratory comparisons appear in Appendix Section A.6. The seed speech estimates are 2.9

6 Conclusion

What does campaign money buy? This paper examines whether relationships formed early in a political career remain visible in what legislators choose to work on. I compare seed donor interests with members' largest non-seed backers and their districts' economic interests across voting, bill activity, and committee speech.

Early donor ties are clearest where legislators can choose what to work on. Seed donor interests are associated with bill sponsorship and committee participation, while their relationship with party-line voting is small. In committee speech, seed alignment exceeds district alignment overall and exceeds both district and largest-donor alignment on committees whose jurisdiction covers the member's seed topics. Largest-donor interests are associated with participation elsewhere. The distinctive relationship between early backing and legislative attention therefore appears where members' committees give them an opportunity to address their early supporters' concerns.

The findings are consistent with several explanations for why early donor ties remain associated with legislative attention. Early donors may identify candidates who share their priorities, sustain relationships through information and legislative support, or generate a sense of obligation. The observational design does not distinguish among these accounts. The outcomes capture attention to policy topics rather than support for donors' preferred positions. Further research could examine the substance of members' remarks and bill provisions, the role of early ties in committee assignments, and their relationship with amendments, committee votes, and agency intervention.

Campaign relationships may matter for representation even when their association with floor voting is small. Early backers' interests remain visible in the issues members sponsor and discuss, especially where committee jurisdiction gives members an opportunity to address

points in the first session and 2.1 points in the election year, with no clear difference by distance from the election. The estimate is 2.8 points at hearings with private-sector witnesses ($p < 0.001$) and 0.5 points at hearings with only government witnesses. It is larger at subcommittee hearings than at full-committee hearings (3.3 versus 0.6 points; difference $p < 0.10$). Differences by party, majority status, and tenure are not significant.

those concerns. Legislative attention is scarce, and deciding where to spend it is itself a choice about representation. Understanding money in politics therefore requires asking whose concerns receive that attention, as well as how legislators vote.

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A Appendix

Additional results, including the full heterogeneity tables, every result under the alternative seed definitions, and further descriptive tables, are in the Online Supplement.

A.1 Data and Measurement

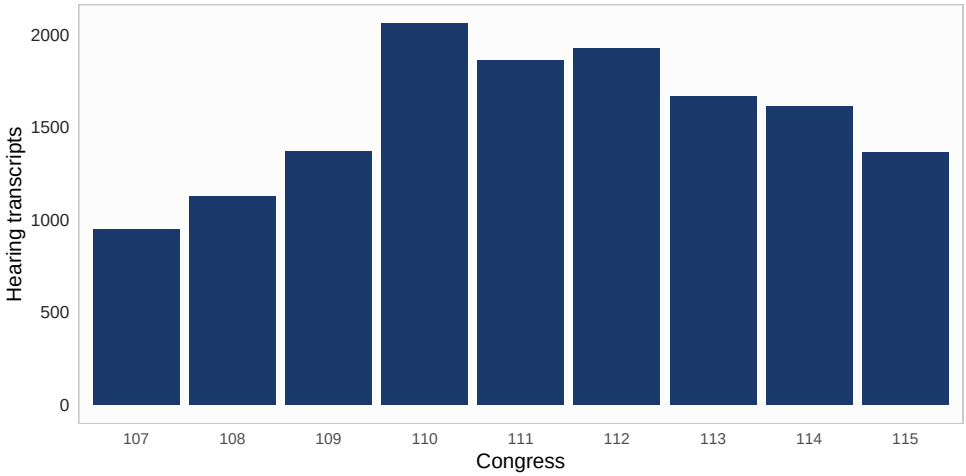


Figure A1: House Committee Hearing Transcripts by Congress

Note: All 13,930 House committee hearing transcripts available from the Government Publishing Office, 107th–115th Congresses.

Table A1: Analysis Samples

Activity	Observations	Members	Units	
Committee speech	184,528	350	12,977	hearings
Bill sponsorship / cosponsorship	10,500	350	30	topics
Roll-call voting	8,693	350	29	topics

Note: Speech: member × hearing rows for members on the hearing committee's roster (unique surnames), 107th–115th Congresses. Bills and votes: freshman member × policy topic in the member's first Congress.

Table A2: Most Common Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests

A. Donor interests, share of members (mapped topic in parentheses)					
Seed (Q1–Q3)		Late seed (Q4)		Largest donor	
Insurance (Insurance)	28%	Abortion (Women)	12%	Banks (Commercial Banks, Savings Loans)	28%
Banks (Commercial Banks, Savings Loans)	27%	Healthcare (Health Services HMOs)	12%	Doctors (Health Services HMOs)	22%
Utilities (Electric Utilities Energy)	26%	Doctors (Health Services HMOs)	11%	Abortion (Women)	22%
Doctors (Health Services HMOs)	24%	Insurance (Insurance)	11%	Oil (Electric Utilities Energy)	21%
Healthcare (Health Services HMOs)	23%	Real Estate (Real Estate)	9%	Insurance (Insurance)	16%
Automobiles (Automotive)	21%	Banks (Commercial Banks, Savings Loans)	8%	Automobiles (Automotive)	14%
Oil (Electric Utilities Energy)	18%	Defense (Defense Hawks)	7%	Real Estate (Real Estate)	13%
Construction (Real Estate)	15%	Alcohol (Retail Sales)	7%	Restaurants (Retail Sales)	12%
Finance (Finance)	14%	Dentists (Health Services HMOs)	7%	Environment (Animal Rights Environment)	11%
Power Utilities (Electric Utilities Energy)	12%	Environment (Animal Rights Environment)	6%	Finance (Finance)	9%
B. Policy topics used in the analysis; share of members					
Seed (Q1–Q3)		Largest donor		District	
Health ServicesHMOs	32%	Health ServicesHMOs	31%	Agriculture	83%
Electric Utilities Energy	25%	Electric Utilities Energy	25%	Electric Utilities Energy	74%
Savings Loans	25%	Women	24%	Manufacturing	73%
Commercial Banks	24%	Retail Sales	17%	Business Associations	63%
Real Estate	20%	Real Estate	17%	Software Computers Technology	57%
Insurance	19%	Insurance	14%	Waste Management	56%
Retail Sales	18%	Savings Loans	12%	Entertainment Recreation	53%
Women	18%	Automotive	11%	Real Estate	53%

Note: 347 freshman members, 107th–115th Congresses, first election cycle. Panel A rebuilds interests from FEC PAC contributions (step 19): seed = interest's first contribution in the first three quarters of the pre-primary window; late seed = last quarter; largest donor = top three non-seed interests by total contributions. Panel B: the topic-level indicators used in the models; district = topics of the district's top-three location-quotient industries.

Table A3: Overlap among Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests (Member Level)

Members with at least one seed (Q1–Q3) topic	237 of 350
Seed topics per member (mean)	4.10
District topics per member (mean)	8.95
Largest-donor topics per member (mean)	2.30
Share of seed topics that are district topics	35%
Share of seed topics that are largest-donor topics	10%
Share of largest-donor topics that are district topics	38%
Members with any seed–district overlap	65%
Members with any seed–largest-donor overlap	32%

Table A4: Pearson Correlations among Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests

	Seed (Q1–Q3)	Largest donor	District
Committee speech: member × hearing (N = 184,528)			
Seed (Q1–Q3)	1		
Largest donor	0.075	1	
District	0.141	0.135	1
Bills and votes: freshman member × topic (N = 10,500)			
Seed (Q1–Q3)	1		
Largest donor	0.018	1	
District	0.060	0.046	1

Note: Pearson correlations between the binary interest indicators used in the main models (seed = interest first funded in Q1–Q3 of the pre-primary window). Speech: the hearing's primary topic matches the interest. Bills and votes: the topic matches the interest in the member's first Congress.

Table A5: How Much Do Interests Aggregate? PAC Composition of Seed Interests

Seed (Q1–Q3) member–interests	1,783
PACs per seed interest (median)	1
Seed interests from a single PAC	60%
Share of seed interest dollars from its largest PAC (median)	100%
Interests: PACs per interest per cycle (median)	4
Interests: within-interest SD of PACs' Republican dollar share (median)	0.11
Interests: share of dollars from PACs leaning against the interest's majority (median)	10%
Seed (Q1–Q3) topics from low-disagreement interests	27%
Seed (Q1–Q3) topics from a dominant PAC (>= 50% of dollars)	86%

Timing of Pre-Primary Contributions

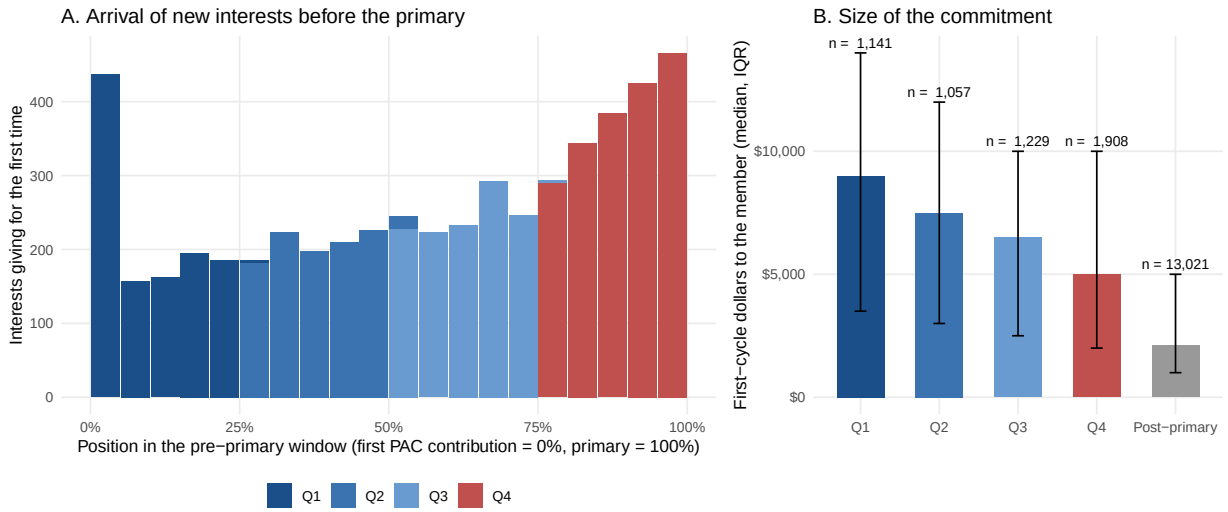


Figure A2: When New Interests First Give to Freshmen, and How Much

Note: Interests that gave to a freshman in the first election cycle. A: interests giving to the member for the first time, by position in the member's pre-primary window (bins of 5%), colored by quarter. The spike at 0% is mechanical, because the window starts with the candidate's first PAC contribution. B: median first-cycle dollars from the interest to the member, with interquartile range, by quarter of first contribution and for interests that first gave after the primary.

Table A6: Are Last-Quarter Pre-Primary Donors Bandwagoners?

Interest characteristic	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Post-primary	Q4 − Q1–Q3 (within member)
Log first-cycle dollars from the interest	8.91	8.72	8.57	8.38	7.70	-0.42*** (0.04)
Interest gave more than $5,000	66%	59%	55%	48%	16%	-14.3*** (1.6)
A PAC in the interest also funded a same-party primary rival	30%	28%	24%	19%		-6.1*** (1.5)
A PAC in the interest funded a primary rival first	28%	28%	24%	21%	22%	-3.1* (1.5)
PACs' share of dollars to incumbents (all House races)	71%	76%	75%	74%	77%	-0.2 (0.7)
PACs' bipartisanship (1 = even split between parties)	43%	48%	46%	45%	50%	-0.1 (1.0)
House candidates funded by the interest's PACs	135.85	153.49	160.05	153.33	143.84	1.23 (3.82)
Member already led the primary field in PAC money	24%	43%	50%	63%	66%	20.5*** (2.9)
New Q4 interests arriving in the last 20 days before the primary				47% (uniform 39%)		7.2*** (1.3)

Note: Interests that gave to a freshman in the first election cycle (18,356 member–interests, 349 members), by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which the interest first gave, or after the primary. Hedging, rival-first, and field-leader measures use the 280 members whose primary had a same-party rival who received PAC money. Access measures describe the interest's PACs across all House candidates that cycle, weighted by dollars to the member. The last column is the coefficient on a Q4 indicator in a regression on Q1–Q4 interests with member fixed effects (percentage points for shares). For the report row, the last column is the observed share of Q4 arrivals after the FEC pre-primary report closes (20 days before the primary) minus the share of the Q4 window that falls after that date. Standard errors clustered by member. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Topic Classification

Table A7: Hearing-Topic Classifier Agreement with Claude Reference Labels on 2,600 Random Hearings

Group	Level	N	Exact (%)	95% CI	Lenient (%)
Overall	All random hearings	2600	78.4	[76.8, 79.9]	92.3
Sample	random500	500	79.8	[76.1, 83.1]	93.0
Sample	random_ext	2100	78.0	[76.2, 79.8]	92.2
Classifier confidence	High	1763	90.3	[88.8, 91.6]	96.7
Classifier confidence	Medium	591	60.1	[56.1, 63.9]	87.8
Classifier confidence	Low	246	37.0	[31.2, 43.2]	72.4
Coder confidence	High	2239	83.3	[81.6, 84.7]	94.5
Coder confidence	Medium	334	49.7	[44.4, 55.0]	81.1
Coder confidence	Low	27	29.6	[15.9, 48.5]	55.6

Note: Reference labels were produced by Claude (a large language model), not a human coder; none of these hearings were used to train the classifier. Lenient also counts a match on either secondary topic. Wilson 95% confidence intervals.

Table A8: Agreement of Alternative Hearing-Topic Sources with Claude Reference Labels (%)

Topic source	Exact agreement
Supervised classifier	78.4
Zero-shot	48.0
BERTopic (mapped)	66.2
STM (mapped)	55.8
keyATM (keywords)	44.4
keyATM (mapped)	50.2

Note: Exact agreement with the 2,600 random hearings with Claude reference labels. Mapped models assign unsupervised topics to categories using the classifier's 1,606 training labels with five-fold cross-fitting.

A.2 Main Results: Full Estimates

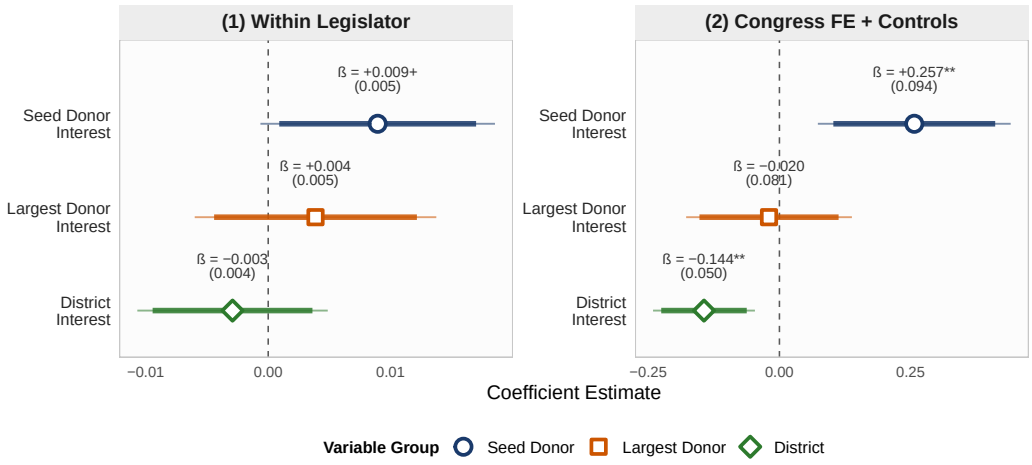


Figure A3: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests and Party-Line Voting

Note: Left: OLS with legislator × Congress and topic fixed effects. Right: fractional logit with Congress fixed effects and controls for party, open-seat entry, district competitiveness, log contributions, and majority status. Legislator × topic in the member's first Congress. Circles denote seed donor interests, squares largest donor interests, and diamonds district interests. Late-seed interests are included in every model. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

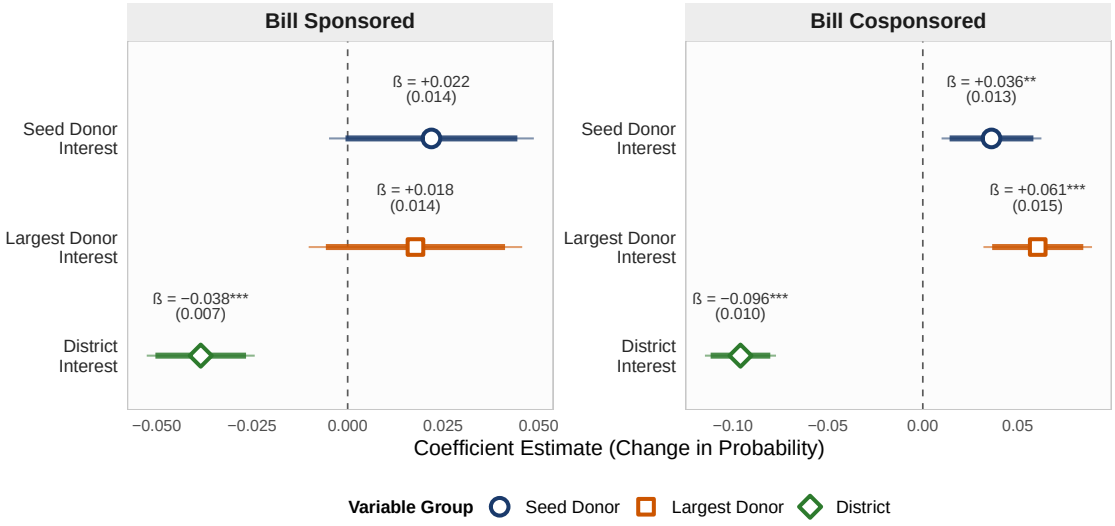


Figure A4: Bill Activity with Congress Fixed Effects and Controls

Note: As Figure 2, but with Congress fixed effects and controls for party, open-seat entry, district competitiveness, log contributions, and majority status instead of legislator × Congress and topic fixed effects. These estimates compare different members. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A9: Party-Line Voting: Seed, Largest Donor, and District Interests (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Party-line vote share		
Topics:	Classifier		Keyword regex
Spec.:	Within MC	Congress FE	Within MC
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	OLS	Frac. logit	OLS
Seed (Q1–Q3)	0.009^{+}	0.257**	0.011***
	(0.005)	(0.094)	(0.003)
Late seed (Q4)	0.008	0.057	0.0007
	(0.008)	(0.137)	(0.006)
Largest donor interest	0.004	-0.020	0.010**
	(0.005)	(0.081)	(0.003)
District interest	-0.003	-0.144**	-0.001
	(0.004)	(0.050)	(0.003)
Republican		-0.103	
		(0.122)	
Open-seat entry		0.161^{+}	
		(0.094)	
Competitive first race		-0.045	
		(0.103)	
Log total contributions		0.004	
		(0.023)	
Majority party		0.339**	
		(0.123)	
Observations	8,693	8,693	8,493
R^2	0.190		0.215
Member × Congress fixed effects	✓		✓
Topic fixed effects	✓		✓
Congress fixed effects		✓	

Note: Within MC = member × Congress and topic fixed effects; Congress FE = Congress fixed effects with controls (fractional logit) . SEs clustered by member. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A10: Bill Sponsorship: Seed, Largest Donor, and District Interests (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Sponsored		
Topics:	Classifier		Keyword regex
Spec.:	Within MC	Congress FE	Within MC
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Seed (Q1–Q3)	0.029*	0.022	0.039**
	(0.013)	(0.014)	(0.014)
Late seed (Q4)	0.013	0.018	0.010
	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.021)
Largest donor interest	-0.005	0.018	0.008
	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.013)
District interest	0.022**	-0.038***	0.018+
	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.009)
Republican		-0.047***	
		(0.010)	
Open-seat entry		-0.010	
		(0.009)	
Competitive first race		0.041***	
		(0.011)	
Log total contributions		-0.004	
		(0.003)	
Majority party		0.027**	
		(0.010)	
Observations	10,500	10,500	10,150
R^2	0.250	0.011	0.195
Member × Congress fixed effects	✓		✓
Topic fixed effects	✓		✓
Congress fixed effects		✓	

Note: Within MC = member × Congress and topic fixed effects; Congress FE = Congress fixed effects with controls (LPM) . SEs clustered by member. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A11: Bill Cosponsorship: Seed, Largest Donor, and District Interests (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Cosponsored		
Topics:	Classifier		Keyword regex
Spec.:	Within MC	Congress FE	Within MC
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Seed (Q1–Q3)	0.014	0.036**	0.030*
	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)
Late seed (Q4)	-0.012	0.034	0.024
	(0.020)	(0.029)	(0.023)
Largest donor interest	-0.013	0.060***	-0.007
	(0.012)	(0.015)	(0.012)
District interest	0.012	-0.096***	-0.010
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.010)
Republican		-0.065***	
		(0.011)	
Open-seat entry		-7.29×10^{-5}	
		(0.009)	
Competitive first race		0.022*	
		(0.010)	
Log total contributions		-0.006*	
		(0.003)	
Majority party		0.017	
		(0.011)	
Observations	10,500	10,500	10,150
R^2	0.479	0.023	0.413
Member × Congress fixed effects	✓		✓
Topic fixed effects	✓		✓
Congress fixed effects		✓	

Note: Within MC = member × Congress and topic fixed effects; Congress FE = Congress fixed effects with controls (LPM) . SEs clustered by member. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A12: Committee Speech: Seed, Largest Donor, and District Interests (seed = Q1–Q3)

Outcome:	Spoke		Speaking turns	
	Spoke		Turns	
Measure:	Top topic	Share	Top topic	Share
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	OLS	OLS	Poisson	Poisson
Seed (Q1–Q3)	0.026**		0.163**	
	(0.008)		(0.060)	
Late seed (Q4)	0.005		0.028	
	(0.012)		(0.105)	
Largest donor interest	0.013*		0.020	
	(0.006)		(0.045)	
District interest	0.005		0.022	
	(0.004)		(0.036)	
Seed (Q1–Q3, share)		0.033**		0.235**
		(0.010)		(0.078)
Late seed (Q4, share)		0.006		0.007
		(0.015)		(0.131)
Largest donor interest (share)		0.018*		0.039
		(0.008)		(0.056)
District interest (share)		0.007		0.022
		(0.005)		(0.042)
Observations	184,254	184,254	155,827	155,827
R^2	0.428	0.428		
Hearing fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Member × committee × Congress × subcommittee membership fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Linear probability models (spoke) and Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (speaking turns) with hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects; committee-roster sample. Standard errors clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

A.3 Committee Jurisdiction and Committee Types

The speech tables include every committee, including the small committees (fewer than 2,000 member–hearing observations or 100 seed-matched observations) that are not shown separately in Figure 5.

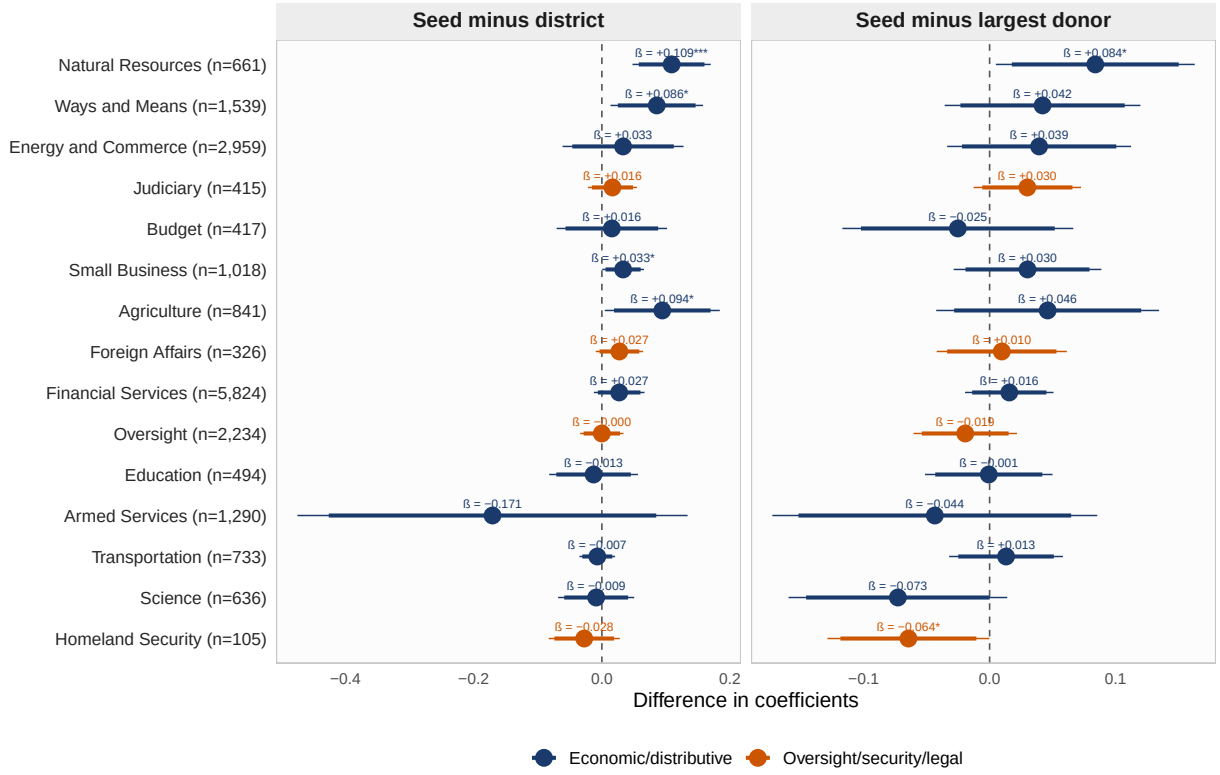


Figure A5: Seed Minus District and Seed Minus Largest Donor in Committee Speech, by Committee

Note: Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A13: Committee Type — Committee Speech (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Seed	Late seed (Q4)	Largest donor	District
Procedural committees				
Non-procedural	0.025**	0.003	0.012*	0.005
	(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.004)
Procedural	0.051	0.044	0.076+	0.022
	(0.035)	(0.037)	(0.039)	(0.044)
Non-procedural minus Procedural	-0.026	-0.041	-0.063	-0.017
	(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.039)	(0.045)
Deering–Smith type				
Constituency	0.019+	-0.026	0.007	-0.001
	(0.010)	(0.022)	(0.010)	(0.007)
Other	-0.021	-0.057	0.036	-0.015
	(0.023)	(0.059)	(0.026)	(0.023)
Policy	0.027*	0.023	0.014+	0.010+
	(0.012)	(0.015)	(0.008)	(0.006)
Prestige	0.053**	0.000	0.027	-0.015
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.017)	(0.020)
Jurisdiction				
Economic/distributive	0.030**	0.002	0.010	0.003
	(0.010)	(0.013)	(0.007)	(0.005)
Oversight/security/legal	0.014	0.011	0.024*	0.010
	(0.009)	(0.022)	(0.010)	(0.008)
Economic/distributive minus Oversight/security/legal	0.015	-0.009	-0.014	-0.007
	(0.013)	(0.024)	(0.012)	(0.009)
Earlier committee definition				
Administrative/all-encompassing	0.021+	0.011	0.028*	0.001
	(0.011)	(0.022)	(0.012)	(0.009)
Policy-making (earlier definition)	0.027**	0.002	0.010	0.006
	(0.010)	(0.013)	(0.007)	(0.005)
Administrative/all-encompassing minus Policy-making (earlier definition)	-0.006	0.009	0.017	-0.005
	(0.014)	(0.024)	(0.013)	(0.010)
Seed-aligned committee				
Committee covers a seed topic	0.041**	0.010	-0.002	-0.001
	(0.012)	(0.016)	(0.013)	(0.011)
Committee covers no seed topic	0.008	0.003	0.021***	0.007
	(0.008)	(0.017)	(0.006)	(0.004)
Committee covers a seed topic minus Committee covers no seed topic	0.033*	0.007	-0.023	-0.008
	(0.015)	(0.022)	(0.014)	(0.012)
Topic and jurisdiction				
Topic in core jurisdiction	0.032*	0.020	0.008	0.006
	(0.014)	(0.018)	(0.010)	(0.007)
Topic off core jurisdiction	0.020**	-0.003	0.019**	0.004
	(0.007)	(0.014)	(0.007)	(0.005)
Topic in core jurisdiction minus Topic off core jurisdiction	0.011	0.022	-0.011	0.002
	(0.015)	(0.022)	(0.012)	(0.008)

Note: Each block is one model interacting the seed, largest-donor and district indicators with the moderator's levels; hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership FE; outcome = spoke at the hearing (LPM). Differences between interests are in the companion table. Rows labelled "A minus B" test the difference between levels. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A14: Committee Type — Committee Speech (seed = Q1–Q3): Differences between Interests

	Seed − largest donor	Seed − district	Seed − late seed
Procedural committees			
Non-procedural	0.013	0.020*	0.022+
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.013)
Procedural	-0.024	0.030	0.007
	(0.047)	(0.045)	(0.044)
Non-procedural minus Procedural			
Deering–Smith type			
Constituency	0.012	0.021+	0.045+
	(0.016)	(0.011)	(0.024)
Other	-0.057+	-0.007	0.035
	(0.029)	(0.028)	(0.060)
Policy	0.013	0.017	0.004
	(0.013)	(0.015)	(0.017)
Prestige	0.026	0.068*	0.053**
	(0.030)	(0.028)	(0.019)
Jurisdiction			
Economic/distributive	0.019	0.027*	0.027+
	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.015)
Oversight/security/legal	-0.010	0.004	0.003
	(0.015)	(0.013)	(0.021)
Economic/distributive minus Oversight/security/legal			
Earlier committee definition			
Administrative/all-encompassing	-0.006	0.020	0.011
	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.020)
Policy-making (earlier definition)	0.017	0.021+	0.025
	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.016)
Administrative/all-encompassing minus Policy-making (earlier definition)			
Seed-aligned committee			
Committee covers a seed topic	0.042**	0.042*	0.031+
	(0.016)	(0.020)	(0.016)
Committee covers no seed topic	-0.013	0.001	0.005
	(0.011)	(0.010)	(0.018)
Committee covers a seed topic minus Committee covers no seed topic			
Topic and jurisdiction			
Topic in core jurisdiction	0.023	0.026	0.012
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.021)
Topic off core jurisdiction	0.001	0.016+	0.023
	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.015)
Topic in core jurisdiction minus Topic off core jurisdiction			

Note: Each block is one model interacting the seed, largest-donor and district indicators with the moderator's levels; hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership FE; outcome = spoke at the hearing (LPM). Each column is the difference between two coefficients in the same model. Rows labelled "A minus B" test the difference between levels. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A15: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Alignment in Committee Speech, Every Committee (Spoke at the Hearing)

Committee	Rows	Seed rows	Seed	Late seed (Q4)	Largest donor	District
Financial Services	23,257	5,824	0.031^{+}	0.035^{+}	0.015^{+}	0.004
			(0.016)	(0.020)	(0.009)	(0.011)
Oversight	22,990	2,234	0.007	0.025	0.026^{+}	0.007
			(0.013)	(0.032)	(0.015)	(0.010)
Foreign Affairs	19,895	326	0.031^{+}	-0.018	0.021	0.004
			(0.016)	(0.023)	(0.020)	(0.012)
Energy and Commerce	18,829	2,959	0.047	0.032	0.007	0.014
			(0.041)	(0.051)	(0.022)	(0.013)
Transportation	15,796	733	-0.006	-0.002	-0.019	0.001
			(0.011)	(0.039)	(0.020)	(0.011)
Judiciary	12,518	415	0.044**	0.017	0.014	0.027
			(0.015)	(0.028)	(0.013)	(0.019)
Armed Services	12,276	1,290	-0.005	-0.237***	0.039	0.166
			(0.072)	(0.035)	(0.033)	(0.116)
Science	9,747	636	-0.020	-0.073*	0.052*	-0.011
			(0.032)	(0.035)	(0.024)	(0.014)
Small Business	8,924	1,018	0.041*	0.025	0.011	0.008
			(0.019)	(0.046)	(0.019)	(0.014)
Education	8,042	494	0.000	0.009	0.001	0.013
			(0.025)	(0.026)	(0.015)	(0.019)
Homeland Security	7,845	105	-0.035	-0.043	0.030	-0.007
			(0.023)	(0.065)	(0.029)	(0.023)
Veterans Affairs†	6,790	0			0.203	-0.087
					(0.383)	(0.186)
Natural Resources	4,556	661	0.069**	-0.073	-0.015	-0.040
			(0.022)	(0.103)	(0.032)	(0.028)
Ways and Means	4,394	1,539	0.060*	-0.012	0.018	-0.025
			(0.025)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.021)
Agriculture	3,782	841	0.039	-0.012	-0.007	-0.055
			(0.027)	(0.033)	(0.028)	(0.038)
Budget	2,300	417	0.042	0.048	0.068^{+}	0.027
			(0.035)	(0.037)	(0.039)	(0.044)
Appropriations†	1,417	96	0.040	-0.015	-0.039	-0.005
			(0.038)	(0.025)	(0.027)	(0.031)
Other†	799	253	-0.019	-0.062	0.019	-0.126
			(0.052)	(0.144)	(0.053)	(0.151)
House Administration†	320	4	0.400***		0.109*	-0.278
			(0.052)		(0.050)	(0.262)
Rules†	35	3	-0.060	0.004	0.577^{+}	0.285
			(0.693)	(0.341)	(0.344)	(0.535)
Intelligence†	16	2				

Note: One LPM (outcome: spoke at the hearing) model interacting the seed (Q1–Q3), late-seed (Q4), largest-donor, and district indicators with every committee; hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Rows = member–hearing rows; seed rows = rows whose hearing topic is one of the member's seed topics. †Fewer than 2,000 rows or 100 seed rows: estimates are imprecise and are not shown in the main committee figure. Blank cells: no rows with that interest on the committee. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

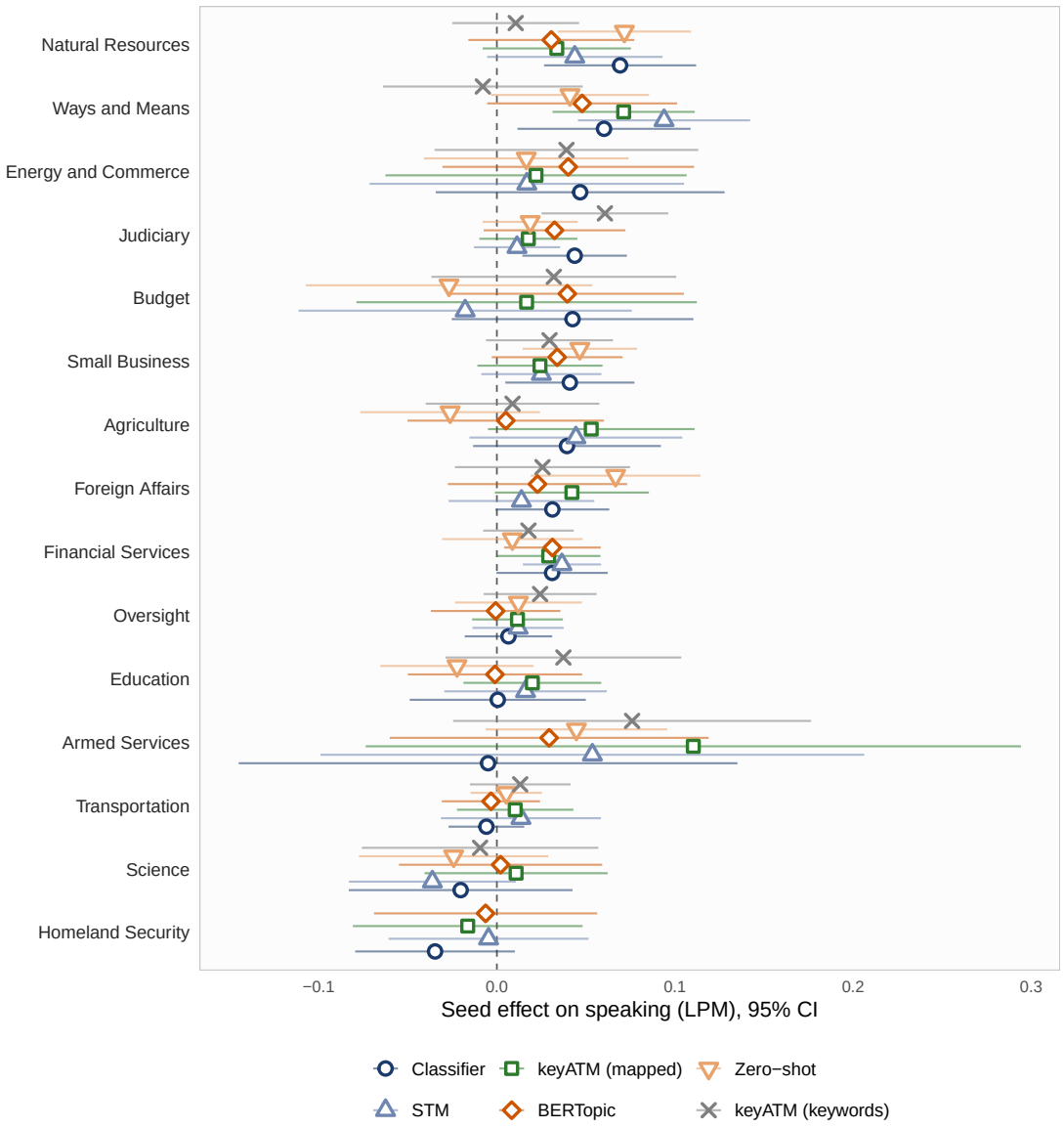


Figure A6: Seed Alignment by Committee Grouping and Hearing-Topic Source

Note: Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A16: Seed Alignment in Bill Activity by Committee

	Sponsored		Cosponsored	
	Seed	Seed − district	Seed	Seed − district
Jurisdiction match (pooled)				
Topic in member's committee jurisdiction	0.048^{+}	-0.039	0.022	-0.014
	(0.029)	(0.038)	(0.019)	(0.025)
Topic outside member's committees	0.020	0.016	0.010	0.005
	(0.014)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.019)
Topic in member's committee jurisdiction minus other	0.029		0.012	
	(0.032)		(0.024)	
Topic's committee type (pooled)				
Economic/distributive committee topic	0.037*	0.009	0.030*	0.026
	(0.016)	(0.020)	(0.013)	(0.016)
Oversight/security/legal committee topic	0.043	0.043	0.020	0.020
	(0.045)	(0.045)	(0.015)	(0.015)
Economic/distributive committee topic minus other	-0.006		0.009	
	(0.048)		(0.019)	
Members of the committee (A)				
Agriculture	0.033	-0.025	0.020	0.009
	(0.035)	(0.036)	(0.023)	(0.031)
Armed Services	-0.056*	-0.044^{+}	0.050*	0.057*
	(0.024)	(0.026)	(0.021)	(0.026)
Budget	0.036	-0.004	0.044	0.042
	(0.030)	(0.033)	(0.030)	(0.037)
Education	0.006	-0.033	-0.027	-0.036
	(0.029)	(0.034)	(0.029)	(0.036)
Energy and Commerce	-0.058	-0.080^{+}	-0.011	0.034
	(0.042)	(0.048)	(0.033)	(0.044)
Financial Services	0.044*	0.028	-0.002	-0.018
	(0.022)	(0.027)	(0.022)	(0.029)
Foreign Affairs	-0.046	-0.040	0.060*	0.071*
	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.027)	(0.033)
Homeland Security	-0.027	-0.013	0.062**	0.067*
	(0.026)	(0.030)	(0.023)	(0.032)
Judiciary	-0.018	-0.039	0.048	0.058
	(0.032)	(0.036)	(0.040)	(0.049)
Natural Resources	0.065^{+}	0.051	-0.071*	-0.090*
	(0.038)	(0.045)	(0.033)	(0.041)
Oversight	0.026	0.012	0.016	0.005
	(0.020)	(0.023)	(0.020)	(0.027)
Science	0.016	0.007	0.044	0.016
	(0.036)	(0.040)	(0.035)	(0.036)
Small Business	0.026	0.008	-0.023	-0.044
	(0.028)	(0.032)	(0.030)	(0.036)
Transportation	0.006	-0.023	0.005	-0.002
	(0.022)	(0.026)	(0.022)	(0.026)
Veterans Affairs	-0.063	-0.051	0.060^{+}	0.081^{+}
	(0.047)	(0.051)	(0.032)	(0.046)
Ways and Means	0.052	0.014	-0.027	-0.055
	(0.032)	(0.035)	(0.031)	(0.043)
Bills on topics in the committee's jurisdiction (B)				
Agriculture	0.195*	0.065	-0.006	-0.090
	(0.076)	(0.085)	(0.048)	(0.072)
Budget	-0.062	-0.240*	-0.017	-0.027
	(0.073)	(0.106)	(0.015)	(0.021)
Energy and Commerce	0.013	-0.035	0.032*	0.074**
	(0.041)	(0.050)	(0.013)	(0.024)
Financial Services	0.008	-0.044	0.003	-0.023
	(0.021)	(0.029)	(0.019)	(0.025)
Judiciary	0.044	0.044	0.013	0.013
	(0.044)	(0.044)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Natural Resources	0.040	-0.017	0.031	0.073*
	(0.051)	(0.083)	(0.019)	(0.029)
Transportation	0.011	0.018	0.164***	0.164**
	(0.035)	(0.038)	(0.049)	(0.056)
Ways and Means	-0.022	-0.109**	0.004	0.029
	(0.033)	(0.041)	(0.039)	(0.054)

Table A17: Principal Tests: Raw and Adjusted p-Values

				Three tests		Five tests	
Test	Estimate	SE	Raw p	Holm	BH	Holm	BH
Bill sponsorship: seed	2.9	1.3	0.027	0.055	0.041	0.106	0.046
Speech: economic/distributive minus oversight/security/legal committees	1.5	1.3	0.233	0.233	0.233	0.233	0.233
Speech: prestige committees	5.3	1.8	0.002	0.007	0.007	0.012	0.012
Speech: final term minus earlier terms	-2.9	1.4	0.042			0.106	0.052
Speech: seed interest still giving minus lapsed	3.2	1.4	0.026			0.106	0.046

Note: Estimates in percentage points, from the models reported in the text (seed = Q1–Q3). The three-test family contains the sponsorship estimate and the two committee-venue tests; the five-test family adds the final-term and persistence tests. These tests were selected after the analyses reported in the paper, not specified in advance; the adjustments correct for multiplicity within each family but not for the broader search across seed definitions, committee groupings, and moderators. Holm = Holm's step-down correction of the familywise error rate; BH = Benjamini–Hochberg false discovery rate.

A.4 Competing Explanations and Measurement

Table A18: Separating Seed from District Interests: Overlap Patterns and Same-Seat Comparisons (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Spoke (LPM)	Turns (PPML)
Mutually exclusive patterns		
Seed only	0.030**	0.230**
	(0.010)	(0.078)
Seed + district	0.040***	0.252**
	(0.010)	(0.088)
Seed + largest donor	0.028+	0.092
	(0.016)	(0.097)
District only	0.006	0.059
	(0.005)	(0.045)
Largest donor only	0.021**	0.096+
	(0.006)	(0.055)
Seed only - district only	0.024*	0.172*
	(0.010)	(0.082)
Seed only - largest donor only	0.010	0.134
	(0.012)	(0.093)
Seed added to district	0.034**	0.194*
	(0.011)	(0.085)
Later seed only	0.016	0.104
	(0.016)	(0.131)
Later seed + district	-0.006	-0.068
	(0.013)	(0.170)
Seed only - later seed only	0.014	0.126
	(0.018)	(0.148)
Same seat, different member		
Seed	0.008	0.323*
	(0.016)	(0.147)
Late seed (Q4)	0.023	0.008
	(0.034)	(0.221)
Undated seed		
Largest donor	-0.005	-0.019
	(0.008)	(0.081)
District	0.009	0.149+
	(0.010)	(0.083)
Seed - largest donor	0.013	0.342*
	(0.017)	(0.150)
Seed - district	-0.001	0.174
	(0.018)	(0.168)
Seed - late seed	-0.015	0.315
	(0.035)	(0.221)

Note: Mutually exclusive patterns: hearing matches only the seed, the seed and district, etc. Same seat, different member: adds congressional seat × map era × hearing topic fixed effects. Linear probability models (spoke) and Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (speaking turns) with hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects; committee-roster sample. Standard errors clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A19: Separating Seed from District Interests: Alternative District Measures and Within-Member Designs (seed = Q1–Q3)

	Spoke (LPM)	Turns (PPML)
Alternative district measure		
Seed [district_interest_top1]	0.026**	0.164**
	(0.008)	(0.060)
Late seed (Q4) [district_interest_top1]	0.004	0.025
	(0.012)	(0.105)
District [district_interest_top1]	0.007	0.069+
	(0.006)	(0.041)
Seed - district [district_interest_top1]	0.019+	0.095
	(0.011)	(0.080)
Seed [district_interest_wp_top3]	0.026**	0.163**
	(0.008)	(0.059)
Late seed (Q4) [district_interest_wp_top3]	0.005	0.028
	(0.012)	(0.104)
District [district_interest_wp_top3]	0.005	0.009
	(0.005)	(0.037)
Seed - district [district_interest_wp_top3]	0.021+	0.155*
	(0.011)	(0.075)
Seed [district_interest_raw_top3]	0.026**	0.163**
	(0.008)	(0.060)
Late seed (Q4) [district_interest_raw_top3]	0.005	0.029
	(0.012)	(0.104)
District [district_interest_raw_top3]	-0.000	0.014
	(0.007)	(0.059)
Seed - district [district_interest_raw_top3]	0.026*	0.148+
	(0.011)	(0.086)
Ideological vs economic seed		
Seed ideological topic	0.045*	0.351**
	(0.022)	(0.122)
Seed economic topic	0.024**	0.153*
	(0.009)	(0.063)
Within member-topic (redistricting)		
District change, non-seed topic	0.006	0.135*
	(0.008)	(0.066)
District change, seed topic	0.009	0.366+
	(0.020)	(0.199)
District change, later seed topic	0.051	-0.095
	(0.037)	(0.305)

Note: Alternative district measures replace the top-three location-quotient definition. Within member-topic: member × topic fixed effects, so district effects come from within-member changes in district interests (mostly redistricting). Linear probability models (spoke) and Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (speaking turns) with hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects; committee-roster sample. Standard errors clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A20: Mutually Exclusive Combinations of Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests: Committee Speech

Topic matches	Rows	Spoke (1)	Turns PPML (2)	Turns | spoke (3)
Seed only	9,954	0.030**	0.227**	0.965
		(0.010)	(0.078)	(0.728)
Seed + largest donor	1,781	0.023	0.027	-0.777
		(0.016)	(0.135)	(0.953)
Seed + district	5,490	0.040***	0.243**	0.200
		(0.011)	(0.085)	(0.653)
Seed + largest donor + district	2,625	0.031	0.131	0.225
		(0.020)	(0.091)	(1.062)
Largest donor only	15,039	0.021**	0.116*	-0.217
		(0.007)	(0.055)	(0.562)
District only	28,086	0.006	0.053	0.044
		(0.005)	(0.044)	(0.330)
Largest donor + district	7,473	0.019+	0.032	0.396
		(0.011)	(0.075)	(0.556)
Seed only − largest donor only		0.009	0.111	1.182
		(0.012)	(0.092)	(0.863)
Seed only − district only		0.024*	0.174*	0.921
		(0.011)	(0.082)	(0.708)
Seed added to largest donor (S+L − L)		0.002	-0.089	-0.560
		(0.017)	(0.138)	(0.929)
Seed added to district (S+D − D)		0.034**	0.190*	0.156
		(0.011)	(0.085)	(0.634)
Seed added to both (S+L+D − L+D)		0.012	0.100	-0.170
		(0.022)	(0.106)	(1.130)
Observations		184,254	155,827	39,669

Note: Each topic falls in exactly one category; the reference category is a topic that matches none of the three interests. Late (Q4) and undated seed enter as separate controls. Rows below the line are differences between categories from the same model. Member × hearing; hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects (column 3: members who spoke). Rows = member–hearings in each category. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A21: Mutually Exclusive Combinations of Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Interests: Bills and Votes

Topic matches	Rows	Party-line vote (1)	Sponsored (2)	Cosponsored (3)
Seed only	552	0.012^{+}	0.002	0.001
		(0.006)	(0.015)	(0.014)
Seed + largest donor	46	0.021*	0.090	0.002
		(0.009)	(0.067)	(0.040)
Seed + district	330	0.005	0.068**	0.043*
		(0.008)	(0.024)	(0.021)
Seed + largest donor + district	43	-0.015	0.104	0.016
		(0.023)	(0.068)	(0.039)
Largest donor only	460	-0.000	-0.037*	-0.021
		(0.007)	(0.017)	(0.016)
District only	2,504	-0.003	0.011	0.006
		(0.004)	(0.009)	(0.011)
Largest donor + district	256	0.012	0.042^{+}	0.007
		(0.008)	(0.025)	(0.021)
Seed only − largest donor only		0.012	0.039^{+}	0.022
		(0.009)	(0.021)	(0.019)
Seed only − district only		0.015*	-0.009	-0.006
		(0.007)	(0.016)	(0.016)
Seed added to largest donor (S+L − L)		0.021^{+}	0.127^{+}	0.024
		(0.011)	(0.068)	(0.042)
Seed added to district (S+D − D)		0.008	0.057*	0.036^{+}
		(0.008)	(0.024)	(0.021)
Seed added to both (S+L+D − L+D)		-0.027	0.062	0.009
		(0.024)	(0.071)	(0.043)
Observations		8,693	10,500	10,500

Note: Each topic falls in exactly one category; the reference category is a topic that matches none of the three interests. Late (Q4) and undated seed enter as separate controls. Rows below the line are differences between categories from the same model. Freshman member × topic; member × Congress and topic fixed effects. Rows = member–topics in each category; categories combining seed and largest-donor interests are small. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A22: Seed Alignment by the Homogeneity of Seed Interests

	Speech: spoke	Sponsorship	Cosponsorship
Partisan disagreement within interest			
Seed, low-disagreement interests	0.021	0.001	-0.003
	(0.014)	(0.021)	(0.023)
Seed, high-disagreement interests	0.027***	0.039*	0.019
	(0.008)	(0.015)	(0.013)
Low minus high	-0.006	-0.038	-0.022
	(0.013)	(0.024)	(0.022)
Concentration across PACs			
Seed, dominated by one PAC	0.019*	0.022	0.008
	(0.008)	(0.014)	(0.013)
Seed, spread across PACs	0.059***	0.064*	0.043^{+}
	(0.015)	(0.029)	(0.026)
Dominated minus spread	-0.041**	-0.042	-0.034
	(0.015)	(0.030)	(0.024)

Note: Seed (Q1–Q3) topics split by whether every seed interest on the topic has below-median within-interest partisan disagreement (dollar-weighted SD of member PACs' Republican share), and by whether a single PAC supplied at least half of each seed interest's pre-primary dollars. Main-specification fixed effects; late seed, largest-donor and district indicators included. SEs clustered by member.

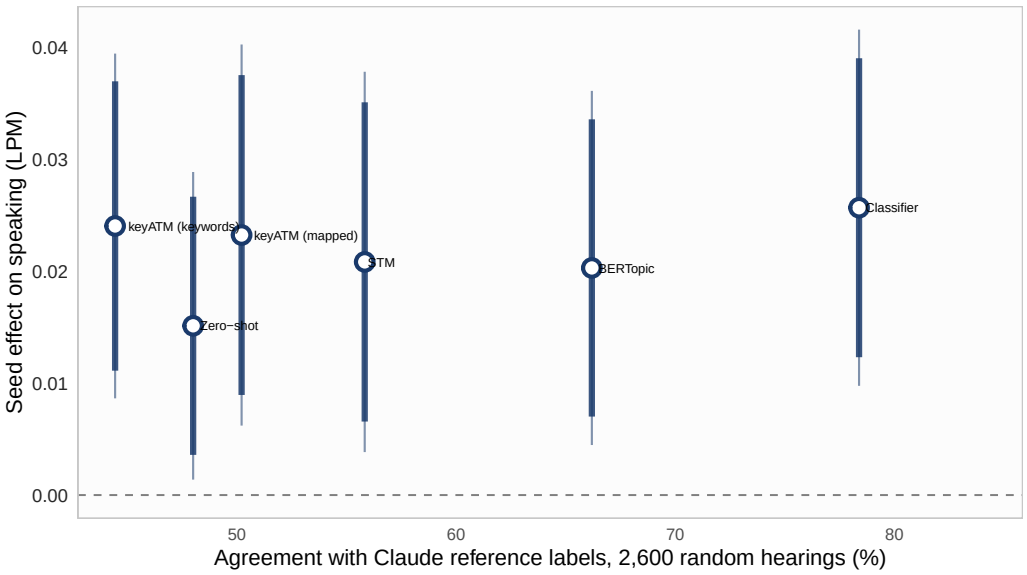


Figure A7: Seed Relationship with Committee Speech by Hearing-Topic Source

Note: Seed coefficient on speaking (main specification) with 95% confidence intervals, against each topic source's agreement with the reference labels on 2,600 random hearings.

Table A23: Committee Speech Results by Hearing-Topic Source (seed = Q1–Q3)

Topic source	Agreement (%)	Seed	Late seed (Q4)	Largest donor	District
Supervised classifier	78.4	0.026**	0.005	0.013*	0.005
		(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.004)
STM (mapped)	55.8	0.021*	0.009	0.013*	-0.002
		(0.009)	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.005)
keyATM (mapped)	50.2	0.023**	0.007	0.013+	-0.003
		(0.009)	(0.012)	(0.007)	(0.005)
BERTopic (mapped)	66.2	0.020*	-0.005	0.012*	0.005
		(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.005)	(0.004)
Zero-shot	48.0	0.015*	-0.003	0.014*	-0.000
		(0.007)	(0.013)	(0.007)	(0.004)
keyATM (keywords)	44.4	0.024**	0.021	0.021***	-0.000
		(0.008)	(0.014)	(0.006)	(0.004)

Note: Agreement = exact agreement with 2,600 random hearings with Claude reference labels. Outcome = spoke at the hearing. Linear probability models (spoke) and Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (speaking turns) with hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects; committee-roster sample. Standard errors clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$. Seed (main definition) = interests whose first pre-primary contribution arrived in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC contribution and the primary (Q1–Q3); late seed (Q4) and undated seed interests are separate terms in the same model. Seed (pre-primary) = interests whose first contribution preceded the member's first primary. Seed Q1–Q4 = the same interests by the quarter of the pre-primary window in which their first contribution arrived (Q1 earliest); QU = seed topic without a dated pre-primary contribution in the FEC records.

Table A24: Speaking at All versus Speaking More: The Intensive Margin of Committee Speech

	Spoke (1)	Turns (2)	Turns (3)	log turns (4)	Turns (5)	Turns (6)
Seed	0.026**	0.415	0.040	0.039	0.037	1.433**
	(0.008)	(0.507)	(0.037)	(0.038)	(0.528)	(0.553)
Late seed (Q4)	0.005	-0.066	0.002	0.032	-0.819	0.479
	(0.012)	(0.794)	(0.060)	(0.058)	(0.752)	(0.698)
Largest donor	0.013*	-0.166	-0.018	-0.022	0.191	-0.083
	(0.006)	(0.407)	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.427)	(0.421)
District	0.005	0.088	0.006	0.007	-0.076	-0.306
	(0.004)	(0.278)	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.287)	(0.429)
Seed − largest donor	0.013	0.581	0.058	0.061	-0.154	1.516*
	(0.010)	(0.637)	(0.044)	(0.057)	(0.767)	(0.737)
Seed − district	0.021*	0.326	0.035	0.032	0.113	1.739*
	(0.010)	(0.563)	(0.042)	(0.043)	(0.501)	(0.730)
Sample	All roster members	Members who spoke				
Estimator	LPM	OLS	PPML	OLS (log)	OLS	OLS
Fixed effects	Hearing + member × committee × Congress				Hearing + member × Congress	Congress + committee
Controls						Yes
Observations	184,254	39,669	39,669	39,669	39,813	39,669

Note: Column 1 is the main model (extensive margin). Columns 2–6 restrict to member–hearings in which the member spoke at least once (mean 11.1 turns, median 7). Column 6 is the specification of an earlier version of this paper, with controls for party, open-seat entry, competitive first race, log contributions, terms served, majority status, and the log of other members' turns at the hearing. PPML drops fixed-effect groups with no variation in turns. Seed = Q1–Q3 of the pre-primary window; late seed (Q4) and undated seed enter as separate terms. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A25: Attending versus Speaking: Hearings with a List of Members Present

	Spoke (1)	Attended (2)	Spoke | attended (3)
Seed	0.045*	0.029*	0.038
	(0.017)	(0.014)	(0.024)
Late seed (Q4)	0.018	-0.001	0.050
	(0.017)	(0.016)	(0.033)
Largest donor	0.019^{+}	0.004	0.024
	(0.011)	(0.010)	(0.016)
District	0.013	0.009	0.015
	(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.020)
Seed − largest donor	0.026	0.025^{+}	0.014
	(0.018)	(0.015)	(0.027)
Seed − district	0.032	0.020	0.024
	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.032)
Mean of outcome	0.226	0.365	0.612
Observations	34,034	34,034	12,425

Note: Hearings whose transcript lists the members present (15% of hearings). Column 1: spoke at the hearing (all roster members). Column 2: listed as present. Column 3: spoke, among members listed as present. Members listed as present account for 99% of those who spoke; 0.5% of members not listed spoke. Hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects; linear probability models. Seed = Q1–Q3; late seed (Q4) included. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

A.5 Selection or Exchange: Electoral Conditions, Geography, and the Seed Relationship

These results support the Discussion (Section 5.3).

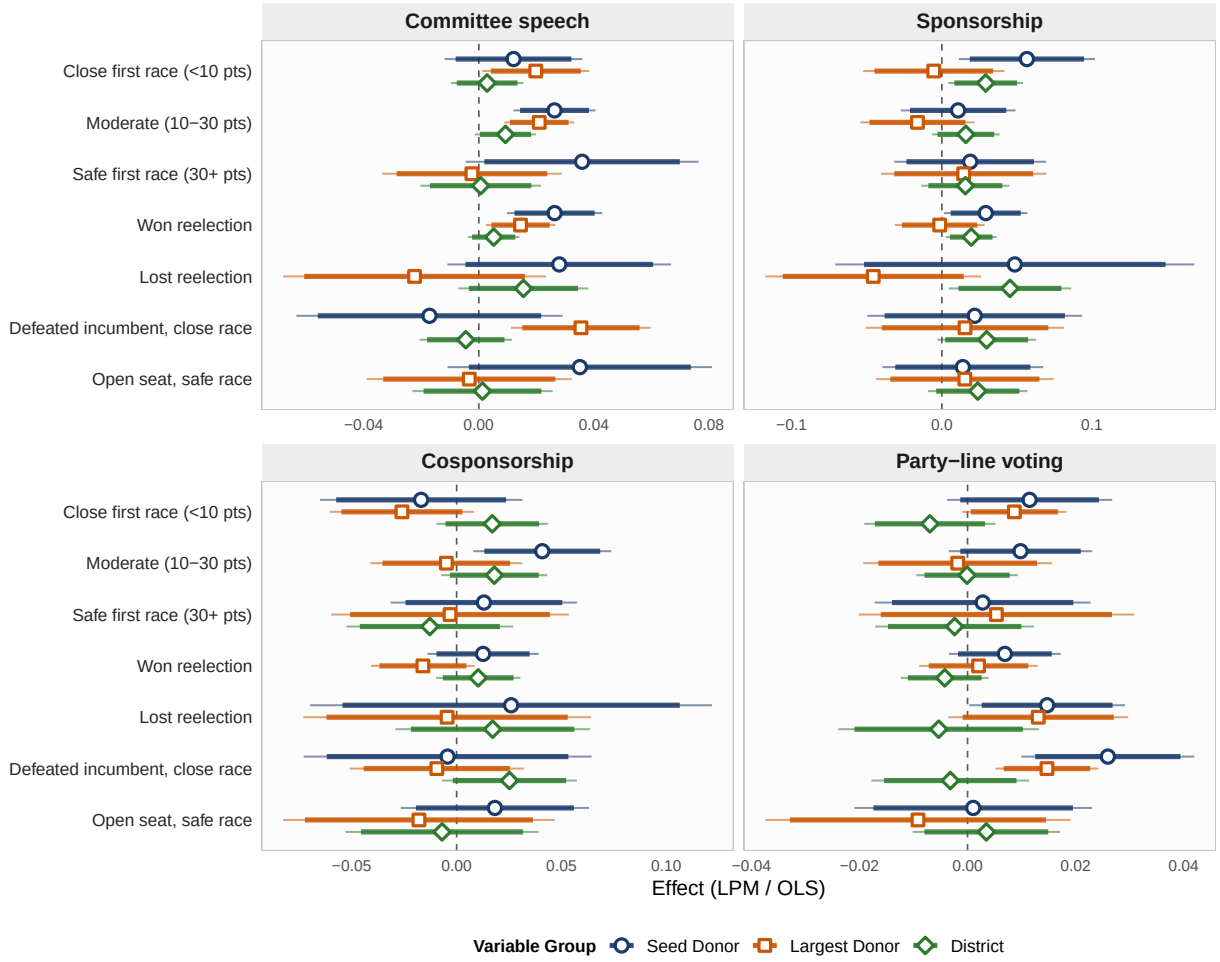


Figure A8: Seed, Largest-Donor, and District Alignment by Electoral Conditions

Note: Each moderator is one model interacting the seed, late-seed, largest-donor, and district indicators with the moderator's levels. Close / moderate / safe = first-race margin under 10, 10–30, and 30+ points. Lost / won reelection = the member's next general election; members not on the ballot are excluded. Speech: hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Bills and votes: legislator × Congress and topic fixed effects. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A26: Electoral Vulnerability and Seed Alignment: Competing Hypotheses (Committee speech and Sponsorship)

	Committee speech		Sponsorship	
	Seed	District	Seed	District
Entry type				
Defeated incumbent	0.002	0.002	0.046	0.030*
	(0.013)	(0.006)	(0.028)	(0.012)
Open seat	0.030**	0.006	0.025^{+}	0.018^{+}
	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.015)	(0.010)
Defeated incumbent minus Open seat	-0.028^{+}	-0.004	0.021	0.012
	(0.016)	(0.008)	(0.031)	(0.014)
First-race margin				
Close first race (<10 pts)	0.012	0.003	0.057*	0.029*
	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.023)	(0.013)
Not close (10+ pts)	0.029**	0.006	0.014	0.016^{+}
	(0.010)	(0.005)	(0.016)	(0.009)
Close first race (<10 pts) minus Not close (10+ pts)	-0.017	-0.003	0.043	0.013
	(0.015)	(0.007)	(0.028)	(0.015)
First-race margin (terciles of interest)				
Close first race (<10 pts)	0.012	0.003	0.057*	0.029*
	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.023)	(0.013)
Moderate (10-30 pts)	0.026***	0.009^{+}	0.011	0.016
	(0.007)	(0.005)	(0.019)	(0.011)
Safe first race (30+ pts)	0.036^{+}	0.001	0.019	0.016
	(0.021)	(0.011)	(0.026)	(0.015)
Next general election				
Lost reelection	0.028	0.016	0.049	0.045*
	(0.020)	(0.012)	(0.061)	(0.021)
Won reelection	0.026**	0.005	0.029*	0.020*
	(0.008)	(0.005)	(0.014)	(0.009)
Lost reelection minus Won reelection	0.002	0.010	0.019	0.026
	(0.021)	(0.012)	(0.062)	(0.022)
Selection vs dependence profiles				
Defeated incumbent, close race	-0.017	-0.005	0.022	0.030^{+}
	(0.024)	(0.008)	(0.036)	(0.017)
Open seat, safe race	0.035	0.001	0.014	0.024
	(0.023)	(0.012)	(0.027)	(0.017)
Other	0.025***	0.008^{+}	0.033*	0.017^{+}
	(0.007)	(0.005)	(0.016)	(0.010)
Continuous margin				
Interaction with margin (per 10 pts)	0.007	-0.002	-0.007	-0.006
	(0.005)	(0.003)	(0.008)	(0.004)

Note: First-race margin = winner's minus runner-up's vote share in the member's first general election (MIT Election Data and Science Lab). Next general election excludes members not on the ballot. Each block is one model interacting seed (Q1–Q3), late-seed, largest-donor, and district indicators with the moderator; speech: hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership FE; bills and votes: member × Congress and topic FE. Continuous margin: interaction of each interest with the margin in 10-point units. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

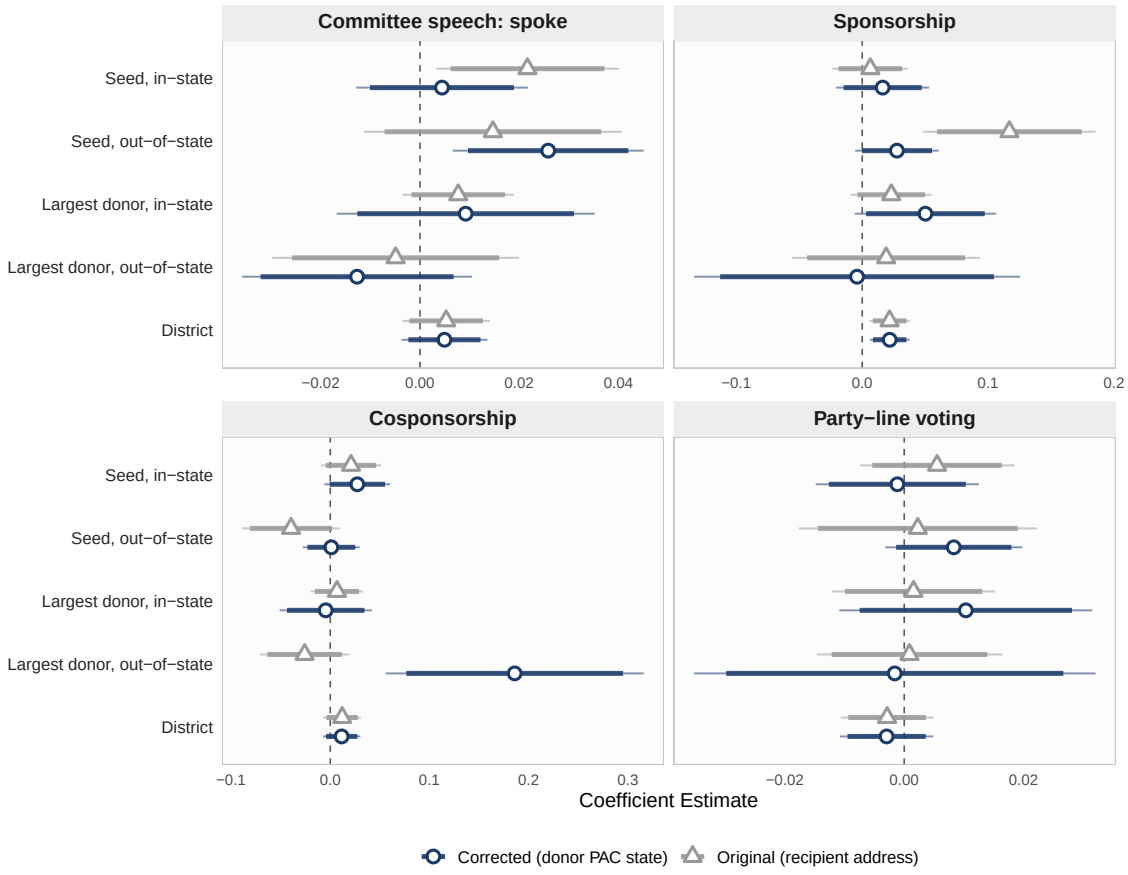


Figure A9: Seed and Largest-Donor Interests by Donor Geography

Note: Filled circles: a seed or largest-donor topic is in-state (out-of-state) when at least one PAC in that interest registered in (outside) the member's state, according to the FEC committee master file, gave in the relevant window. Open circles: the measure used in an earlier version of this paper, based on the recipient committee's address on the FEC record. Speech: hearing and legislator × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Bills and votes: legislator × Congress and topic fixed effects. Thick and thin bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by MC. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table A27: Donor Geography: Corrected In-State Measure vs. Original

	Speech: spoke	Speech: turns	Sponsorship	Cosponsorship	Party-line voting
Corrected (donor PAC state)					
Seed, in-state	0.004	-0.072	0.016	0.027	-0.001
	(0.009)	(0.066)	(0.019)	(0.017)	(0.007)
Seed, out-of-state	0.026**	0.200**	0.028	0.001	0.008
	(0.010)	(0.067)	(0.017)	(0.015)	(0.006)
Seed in - out	-0.021	-0.272*	-0.011	0.026	-0.009
	(0.016)	(0.113)	(0.031)	(0.026)	(0.011)
Largest donor, in-state	0.009	0.150	0.050+	-0.005	0.010
	(0.013)	(0.092)	(0.029)	(0.024)	(0.011)
Largest donor, out-of-state	-0.013	-0.130	-0.004	0.186**	-0.002
	(0.012)	(0.083)	(0.066)	(0.066)	(0.017)
District	0.005	0.020	0.022**	0.012	-0.003
	(0.004)	(0.036)	(0.008)	(0.010)	(0.004)
Original (recipient address)					
Seed, in-state	0.022*	0.152*	0.006	0.021	0.006
	(0.009)	(0.073)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.007)
Seed, out-of-state	0.015	0.046	0.117***	-0.039	0.002
	(0.013)	(0.133)	(0.035)	(0.025)	(0.010)
Seed in - out	0.007	0.107	-0.110*	0.060+	0.003
	(0.019)	(0.176)	(0.043)	(0.033)	(0.015)
Largest donor, in-state	0.008	-0.007	0.023	0.007	0.002
	(0.006)	(0.053)	(0.016)	(0.013)	(0.007)
Largest donor, out-of-state	-0.005	0.009	0.019	-0.026	0.001
	(0.013)	(0.123)	(0.038)	(0.023)	(0.008)
District	0.005	0.024	0.022**	0.012	-0.003
	(0.005)	(0.037)	(0.008)	(0.010)	(0.004)

Note: Corrected: a seed (Q1–Q3) or largest-donor topic is in-state (out-of-state) when at least one PAC in that interest registered in (outside) the member's state, per the FEC committee master, gave in the relevant window. Original: the measure used in an earlier version, which compared the state on the FEC record of the recipient committee with the member's state. Late seed and (corrected) seed topics of unknown origin included. Speech: hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership FE; bills and votes: member × Congress and topic FE. SEs clustered by member.

Table A28: Seed Alignment by Whether the Seed Interest Keeps Giving

	Committee speech: spoke	Committee speech: turns	Sponsorship	Cosponsorship	Party-line voting
Seed, interest still giving	0.026**	0.148**	0.028+	0.016	0.008
	(0.008)	(0.057)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.005)
Seed, interest lapsed (member runs again)	-0.006	-0.185	-0.048	0.021	-0.008
	(0.014)	(0.141)	(0.043)	(0.042)	(0.045)
Seed, member's final term	0.037+	0.299+	0.070	-0.009	0.021***
	(0.019)	(0.164)	(0.046)	(0.026)	(0.006)
Still giving minus lapsed	0.032*	0.333*	0.075+	-0.005	0.016
	(0.014)	(0.153)	(0.044)	(0.045)	(0.045)
Largest donor	0.013*	0.023	-0.004	-0.013	0.004
	(0.006)	(0.045)	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.005)
District	0.005	0.022	0.022**	0.012	-0.003
	(0.004)	(0.036)	(0.008)	(0.010)	(0.004)

Note: Seed (Q1–Q3) topics split by whether a seed interest on that topic contributes to the member during the Congress (for the next election), whether it has lapsed although the member runs again, or whether the member does not run again. Speech: hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership FE, all Congresses. Bills and votes: freshman member × topic in the first Congress; member × Congress and topic FE. Late seed, undated seed, largest-donor and district indicators included. SEs clustered by member in parentheses.

Table A29: The Final-Term Result by How Members Left Office

Member–Congress	Members	Seed rows	Seed	Largest donor	District
Earlier terms (incl. end of window)	306	17,809	0.028**	0.013*	0.005
			(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.005)
Final term: defeated	48	713	0.024^{+}	-0.007	0.022*
			(0.014)	(0.019)	(0.010)
Final term: left office	78	1,328	-0.008	0.031*	-0.003
			(0.017)	(0.015)	(0.012)
Final term: defeated minus earlier terms			-0.004	-0.020	0.017^{+}
			(0.015)	(0.019)	(0.010)
Final term: left office minus earlier terms			-0.037*	0.019	-0.007
			(0.018)	(0.015)	(0.012)

Note: Committee speech (spoke at the hearing, LPM); one model interacting the seed (Q1–Q3), late-seed (Q4), largest-donor, and district indicators with the three groups; hearing and member × committee × Congress × subcommittee-membership fixed effects. Final term = the member's last Congress before the 115th. *Defeated*: on the next general-election ballot and lost. *Left office*: not on the next general-election ballot (retired, sought another office, or lost the primary) or left during the term. Members whose last observed Congress is the 115th are the end of the observation window and are grouped with earlier terms. SEs clustered by member in parentheses. $^{+}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

A.6 Exploratory Moderators

Earlier versions of this paper tested further moderators as hypotheses. I report them here as exploratory analyses; full estimates and figures are in the Online Supplement. Coefficients are the seed effect on speaking, in percentage points.

- **Tenure.** 1.7 ($p < 0.10$) in the first term, 3.3 ($p < 0.001$) in the second and third terms, and 2.2 in the fourth term or later.

- **Fundraising.** 2.0 ($p < 0.05$) in the bottom tercile of first-cycle receipts, 3.2 ($p < 0.001$) in the middle tercile, and 2.3 in the top tercile. The differences are not significant.

- **Party and majority status.** Similar for Democrats (3.2, $p < 0.01$) and Republicans (2.4, $p < 0.05$); 2.0 ($p < 0.10$) in the majority and 3.4 ($p < 0.001$) in the minority (difference not significant).

- **Hearing context.** First session 2.9 ($p < 0.01$) versus election year 2.1 ($p < 0.05$); more than a year before the election 2.9 ($p < 0.01$) versus less than six months 2.4 ($p < 0.01$). Subcommittee hearings 3.3 ($p < 0.001$) versus full-committee hearings 0.6 (difference $p < 0.10$). The estimate is small at hearings with only government witnesses (0.5) and present where private-sector witnesses testify (2.8, $p < 0.001$).

- **Topic confidence.** 2.9 ($p < 0.01$) where the classifier is confident about the hearing's topic and 1.9 ($p < 0.01$) where it is less confident (difference not significant).

- **Current donors.** Similar when the seed interest is also a current largest donor (2.7, $p < 0.01$) and when it is not (3.2, $p < 0.01$).

- **Number of seed topics.** 2.0 ($p < 0.01$) for members with four or more seed topics and 3.8 ($p < 0.05$) for members with two or three; the estimate for members with a single seed topic is imprecise (5.4).